



VALMIKI CORPORATION SCAM
Nagendra resigns from Karnataka Cabinet
STATES » PAGE 6



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e-KYC target unmet for 57 lakh active workers
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IN BRIEF



Centre to replace 2 lakh vehicles in Delhi-NCR

NEW DELHI
The Union government aims to replace more than 2 lakh trucks and buses in Delhi and the National Capital Region (NCR) with BS-VI or electric vehicles within a year under the PARIVARTAN scheme. » **Page 2**

Dalit man forced to eat cattle dung in Maharashtra

MUMBAI
Six “cow vigilantes” have been booked for allegedly assaulting a Dalit man and forcing him to eat cattle dung after accusing him of attempting to sell a bull he had bought in Jalna district of Maharashtra. » **Page 10**

OBC creamy layer income test issue stuck between Ministries: MP

Abhinav Lakshman
NEW DELHI

The issue concerning the two components of OBC creamy layer exclusion – income/wealth test and equivalence of posts – appears to be stuck between two Ministries, said BJP MP and chief of the House panel on welfare of OBCs, Ganesh Singh. He said ideally the Social Justice Ministry should formulate the policy based on the Supreme Court’s reading of the income test in March and then bring it to the Cabinet. “That has not happened yet,” Mr. Singh said.

DETAILS ON
» **PAGE 12**

Nepal disaster toll rises to 579; nearly 2,000 missing

More than 4,500 people, including 85 Indians, rescued; people from more than 30 countries are among those missing; Nepal govt. allows foreign experts to join search after diplomatic pressure



Hopes alive: People wait for a helicopter to arrive at the Nepal Army’s rescue centre in Nuwakot on Friday, hoping their family members would be among those returning. PRABHAT KHANAL

Sanjeev Satgainya
KATHMANDU

The death toll in the Nepal flash floods touched 579 on Friday, even as the search for nearly 2,000 missing people continued for the third day. The Nepal Police said more than 4,500 people had been rescued. Of the 183 Indian tourists reported missing, 85 had been rescued while 98 remained unaccounted for, the Nepal Tourism Board said. Indians account for the highest number of missing foreign nationals. People from more than 30 countries are among those reported missing, the Board said. They include 65 from the U.S., 61 from Ukraine, 51 from Malaysia, 35 from Australia, and 33 from the U.K. Meanwhile, the Nepal government has reversed its earlier decision not to seek assistance from international search and rescue teams. Sources said the government decided to seek

‘No contact with 320 Indians, 400 stranded’

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

At least 320 Indians were unreachable while 400 others were stranded on the Chinese side after the flash floods, the External

help from foreign experts in limited areas following intense diplomatic pressure from countries whose citizens remained unaccounted for. Prime Minister Balendra Shah, in a social media post, said the government was continuously coordinating with India, China and international partners on the assistance and supplies needed for rescue and relief work. Amid questions over how flooding on such a massive scale could have occurred in the Bhotekoshi river in Rasuwa district

Affairs Ministry said on Friday, adding that India stands ready to extend help to Kathmandu to deal with the situation.

FULL REPORT ON
» **PAGE 11**

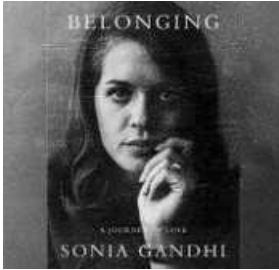
massive surge of water and debris swept downstream into the Bhotekoshi and Trishuli rivers. Nepal’s Department of Hydrology and Meteorology, drawing on satellite imagery shared by the Chinese side, has reached a similar preliminary conclusion. According to an official, the imagery pointed to a combination of an ice avalanche, permafrost movement and a rockslide. “The avalanche originated on the Nepali side, but very close to the boundary, and caused the flood that crossed the Nepal-China border, causing extensive damage on both sides,” said Binod Parajuli, a senior divisional hydrologist at the department’s Flood Forecasting Division. He said there was still a risk of further flooding, although it was unlikely to be on the same scale, and urged people living in the area to exercise caution.

RELATED REPORTS ON
» **PAGE 11**

Penguin India pulls Sonia memoir over ‘PM, RSS references’

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

Penguin Random House India announced on Friday that it is not publishing Congress leader Sonia Gandhi’s much-awaited autobiography, *Belonging: A Journey of Love*, with industry sources saying that the publisher and author had differences regarding content related to her impressions of Prime Minister Narendra Modi from official meetings, his handling of India-China ties, and the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh and its activities. Responding to news reports, the Indian publisher issued the following statement on Friday: “Penguin Random House India is not the publisher of ‘*Belonging*’ in India. Any suggestion that Penguin Random House India decided not to publish ‘*Belonging*’ because the author declined



The cover image of Sonia Gandhi’s autobiography.

editorial changes does not accurately reflect the circumstances.” It added: “As a publisher, it is our responsibility to fact check and provide authors with recommendations that are in the best interests of their books... Throughout the relevant discussions, Penguin Random House India’s position was that we remained willing and keen to publish the book.”

CONTINUED ON
» **PAGE 10**
CONG. SLAMS PUBLISHER
» **PAGE 10**

Dhaka open to Mecca Pact; Opposition backs move

Rabiul Alam
DHAKA

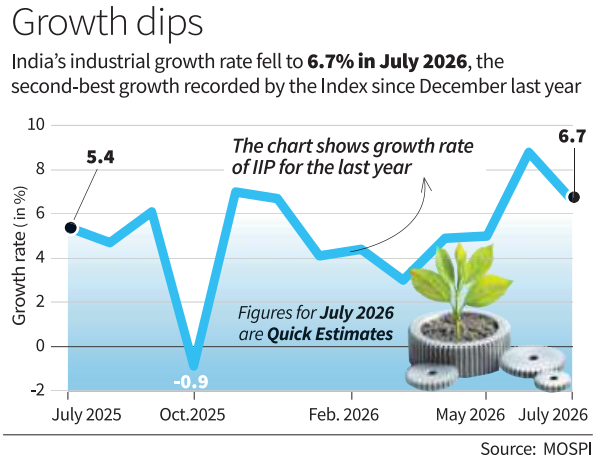
Bangladesh will give positive consideration to joining the Mecca Pact, the tri-lateral defence agreement signed by Saudi Arabia, Turkiye and Pakistan, if its members propose bringing Dhaka into the framework, Bangladesh Foreign Minister Dr. Khalilur Rahman told Parliament on Thursday. Mr. Rahman said Bangladesh’s accession to the pact was not currently under discussion and would depend on the intentions of the agreement’s existing signatories. The government’s such consideration has drawn support from the country’s main Opposition parties, including Bangladesh Jamaat-e-Islami and the National Citizen Party.

FULL REPORT ON
» **PAGE 14**

Industrial growth slows to 6.7% in July from 8.8% in June

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

India’s industrial growth in July 2026 stood at 6.7%, slower than the 8.8% seen in June. July’s performance of the Index of Industrial Production (IIP) was, however, the second-best growth the index has seen since December last year, and was buoyed by the manufacturing and electricity and gas supply sectors. The IIP data released by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation also saw June’s IIP growth rate upgraded from the provisional 7.3% announced last month to 8.8%. According to economists, the data in particular shows a divergence in India’s consumption trends, with rural consumption le-



vels exhibiting weakness. The manufacturing sector grew by 7.3% in July 2026, down from the 9.5% it saw in June, but faster than the 5.1% growth in July of last year. “The manufacturing sector growth was propelled by industries like engineering [electric and

non-electrical] and automobiles [all kinds of transport] besides electronics and plastic and rubber products,” Madan Sabnavis, chief economist at the Bank of Baroda, said.

CONTINUED ON
» **PAGE 10**

India signs Javelin procurement deal with U.S., boosts defence cooperation

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

India signed a Letter of Offer and Acceptance (LOA) with the U.S. on Friday to procure Javelin anti-tank guided missile systems through the U.S. Foreign Military Sales route, marking a significant step in the defence partnership between the two countries. The missile system is being bought under the emergency procurement powers granted to the armed forces to augment critical operational capabilities following Operation Sindoor, defence sources said. The Indian Army is procuring Javelin missiles



The Javelin is a medium-range, anti-tank guided missile designed to engage armoured vehicles and fortified positions. AFP

in limited numbers. Under the emergency framework, the armed forces can make purchases of up to ₹300 crore for each equipment category. Deliveries of contracts under the sixth

tranche of emergency procurements are expected to begin by the end of 2026-27, sources said. The U.S. Embassy in New Delhi welcomed the signing of the LOA, saying

it demonstrated the growing depth of the U.S.-India Major Defence Partnership. U.S. Ambassador to India Sergio Gor said the agreement reflected a defence partnership that was “growing deeper, more capable, and consequential”. He said it demonstrated U.S. support for the Indian Army and created opportunities for the two countries to work together. The Javelin is a medium-range, anti-tank guided missile designed to engage armoured vehicles and fortified positions.

CONTINUED ON
» **PAGE 10**

‘Threatening slogans’: IIT Delhi Director warns protesters of disciplinary action

Ashna Butani
NEW DELHI

IIT Delhi Director Rangan Banerjee on Friday threatened disciplinary action against student protesters for “disrupting the peaceful functioning of the campus, including residential areas, classes, academic and other activities”. In an e-mail to all students, the Director said the institute has been engaging with their representatives in good faith. “Unfortunately, the situation escalated on the night of Thursday... from 10.30 p.m. to 12.30 a.m., a group of protesters extended their agitation into the campus resi-



The protesting students said they held a peaceful march on campus on the intervening night of Thursday and Friday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

dential zones,” it stated. Mr. Banerjee said they resorted to “unsavoury, humiliating and threatening language in their slogans”. This, he said, compromised the “safety, privacy, and peace of faculty members and their families, including young children and

elderly dependents”. The students have been protesting against “systemic issues”, which they claim led to the deaths by suicide of eight students over the past 30 months, including a 31-year-old MSc student on August 22. They have sought an impartial

probe, resignations of two officials for “insensitive remarks” over the incident, and *ex gratia* of ₹1 crore for the deceased’s family. ‘Subjected to profiling’ On the intervening night of Thursday and Friday, the protesters took out a march on campus, which they claimed was peaceful. They also alleged that they were being profiled on Friday night, with unknown persons recording their videos without consent. (Those in distress can contact Tele MANAS at 14416 to seek help)

CAMPUS ON EDGE
» **PAGE 5**

DU student's murder: accused arrested after gunfight in west Delhi

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Delhi Police has arrested Aqib alias Imran, accused of murdering 21-year-old Delhi University (DU) student Muskan Sharma on August 26, after an exchange of fire in Rajouri Garden, a senior officer said on Friday.

The officer added that the 26-year-old "fired four rounds" when a police team tried to apprehend him near the Sub-Registrar Office in west Delhi around 11.15 p.m. on Thursday.

The police fired seven rounds in "self-defence", three of which hit him in the legs, said the officer, adding that no police personnel were injured.

"The police team repeatedly asked him to surrender. Instead, he suddenly took out a pistol and opened fire towards the police party," said Deputy Commissioner of Police (West) Hareshwar Swami.

Muskan, a second-year student of DU's School of Open Learning, was found murdered at her Tilak Nagar residence.

A case under Section

The student had on July 18 approached the police alleging harassment but she did not submit a formal complaint, said an officer

103(i) of the BNS was registered against him at the Tilak Nagar police station on August 27.

He was also booked in a separate case under the Arms Act at the Rajouri Garden police station.

The police said the accused, who had known her for around 18 months, stabbed and strangled her after she decided to end their relationship.

On July 18, the victim had approached the police alleging harassment by Mr. Aqib, said the officer.

"However, she did not submit a formal complaint," added the officer. He was sent to a de-addiction centre and released on July 30 after allegedly harming himself.

The police said Mr. Aqib has been booked in two previous cases, including one under th

Centre to replace 2 lakh buses, trucks in Delhi-NCR in a year

Union govt. to advance deadline to replace old, polluting vehicles with BS-VI or e-vehicles under PARIVARTAN scheme; tax waivers, incentives on offer to accelerate shift to cleaner transport

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

The Union government aims to replace more than 2 lakh trucks and buses in Delhi and the National Capital Region (NCR) with BS-VI or electric vehicles within a year under the PARIVARTAN scheme, bringing forward the two-year implementation timeline approved by the Cabinet, V. Umashankar, the Road Transport and Highways Secretary, said on Friday.

The PARIVARTAN (Programme for Accelerated Renewal and Incentivization of Vehicle Assets for Reducing Transport Air Pollution and Network Emissions) scheme, approved by the Cabinet on June 3 and launched on July 14, seeks to replace trucks and buses registered in Delhi and the NCR districts of Haryana, Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh, which conform to BS-IV or older emission norms.

The scheme is being funded through the National Capital Region Plan-



Trucks, buses account for 3.1% of NCR's total fleet, but form 36% of vehicular emissions, said officials. FILE PHOTO/SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

ning Board under the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs and implemented by the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways.

Although trucks and buses account for just 3.1% of the total vehicle fleet in the region, they contribute 36% of vehicular PM2.5 emissions, officials said at a press briefing to explain the rationale behind the scheme. With a total outlay of ₹9,585 crore, including ₹5,041 crore in Central budgetary support, the scheme offers a package of

incentives to eligible buyers of new BS-VI compliant or stricter diesel and CNG vehicles, as well as electric vehicles.

100% road-tax waiver

These include a 5% interest subvention on eligible vehicle loans for five years, a 100% road-tax waiver for 10 years and exemption from registration fees.

Eligible buyers will also get at least 8% discount on the ex-showroom price from participating vehicle manufacturers.

Buyers of BS-VI diesel or

CNG vehicles will additionally receive monthly fuel vouchers ranging from ₹1,200 to ₹4,800, depending on the vehicle category, for five years, while electric vehicle buyers will be eligible for a one-time incentive ranging from ₹64,000 to ₹2.56 lakh.

The scheme has so far seen more than 1,300 beneficiaries register on the PARIVARTAN portal. Forty-two banks and non-banking financial companies have been onboarded to provide interest subvention on vehicle loans while 15 automobile manufacturers have signed MoUs to extend the mandated discounts to eligible buyers, Mr. Umashankar said.

To avail of the scheme, eligible beneficiaries must scrap their BS-III or older trucks and buses. BS-IV vehicles can be scrapped or sold outside the NCR.

Every winter, air pollution spikes in Delhi-NCR due to meteorological factors and pollution from stubble burning, firecrackers and vehicular emissions.

Recreation spaces for elderly set to come up under new scheme

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi government will soon launch the 'Vayo Anand' scheme under which recreation centres will be set up for senior citizens, the Chief Minister's Office (CMO) stated in a release on Friday. Citizens will be able to enjoy indoor games, interact with others and participate in social activities at these centres, it added.

Facilities such as proper seating arrangements, fans, coolers, televisions and computers, as well as newspapers, magazines and books, will be provided. Additionally, yoga and meditation classes will be organised at these spaces, said the CMO.

Under the scheme, each recreation centre would need to have at least 200 members aged 60 or above. The statement quoted Chief Minister Rekha Gupta as saying that the government will provide assistance of ₹2.4 lakh to set up the recreation spaces.

"Senior citizens are an invaluable asset to society. Ensuring their dignity, health, active lifestyle and



CM Rekha Gupta said ₹2.4 lakh aid will be given for each centre under the 'Vayo Anand' scheme.

social engagement is the Delhi government's priority," she said.

Open for at least 7 hrs.

Ms. Gupta added, "The recreation centres will remain open for at least five days a week and a minimum of seven hours a day. These centres will operate between 7 a.m. and 8 p.m." Preference would be given to centres located on the ground floor or in buildings equipped with lifts. Priority will also be given to organising programmes for women, persons with disabilities and transgender senior citizens, said the Chief Minister. The centres will remain in contact with the local police station and hospitals for quick assistance in cases emergency.

Pedestrian falls into collapsed road, dies from electrocution

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

A 28-year-old pedestrian was electrocuted to death in Surajmal Vihar after a section of the road near an electricity pole reportedly caved in, trapping him up to his waist and bringing him into contact with a live wire, the police said on Friday.

The incident took place on Thursday morning when Sandeep, a caregiver, was returning home after attending to an older person, they said. According to the preliminary inquiry, Sandeep was crossing road number 58 when the unpaved road near an electricity pole on the divider reportedly caved in. He fell into a nearly

three-foot-deep pit and was trapped up to his waist. He died on the spot, said the police.

An officer said they received a PCR call regarding the incident around 7.30 a.m. Following the call, police personnel reached the spot and took Sandeep to a hospital, where doctors declared him dead on arrival.

The officer added that the body has been sent to GTB Hospital for a post-mortem examination, and police are awaiting the report.

The investigation points to alleged negligence by civic agencies, the officer said, adding that they are also examining CCTV footage from cameras near the accident spot.

Sandeep lived with his aunt in Bihari Colony and worked as a caregiver at a house in Surajmal Vihar. He travelled on foot every day for work, said the police.

According to sources, workers had filled the caved-in section of the road with stones, debris and cement by Thursday evening.

BSES
BSES Yamuna Power Limited

BSES Yamuna Power Limited, Delhi
... A joint venture with Govt. of NCT of Delhi

NOTICE INVITING TENDER
Date: 29.08.2026

E-tenders are invited under the Two-Bid System (Un-priced & Priced Bid) for the following works:

NIT No.	Brief Description	EMD Value (₹)	Cost of each Tender Document (non-refundable)	Due Date & Time of Submission	Date & Time of Opening
CMC/BY/26-27/RB/PM/AvS/30	Comprehensive Integrated Facility Management Services including allied services and Security Services in BYPL	33 Lakhs	₹ 5900	18.09.2026 14:30 Hrs	18.09.2026 14:45 Hrs
CMC/BY/26-27/RB/AS/JYS/31	EC26SH4011: Shifting of 11 nos 33KV U/G feeders from old 33KV DTL Yard Rajghat to new 220/33KV GIS DTL Grid S/Stn Rajghat	6.50 Lakhs	₹ 1180	18.09.2026 14:30 Hrs	18.09.2026 14:45 Hrs

For detailed information on the Equipment, Bill of Materials (BOM), Services, Qualifying Requirements, Terms and Conditions, Technical Specifications, and submission of Tender Documents - including any corrigendum - please visit our website at www.bsedelhi.com → **BSES Yamuna Power Ltd → Tenders → Open Tenders**, or access our e-tendering portal at <https://srmprportal.bsedelhi.com/ir/jportal>.
Head (Contracts & Materials)
Regd.Off: BSES Yamuna Power Ltd, Shakti Kiran Building, Karkardooma, Delhi-110032 | CIN: U40109DL2001PLC111525
Website: www.bsedelhi.com TEL: 011-41247111

Indian Institute of Advanced Study
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CORRIGENDUM

With reference to Advertisement No.IIAS/21213/11/0002/2627, published in Employment News and other newspapers on 27 June 2026, the last date for submission of applications for recruitment to the post of **Secretary on Deputation/Foreign Service Terms has been extended.**

Accordingly, the last date for receipt of duly completed applications for the said post is hereby extended up to **5.00 PM on 15 September 2026 (Tuesday).**

Sd/
Secretary
IIAS, Shimla

CBC 21213/11/0003/2627

KOLHAPUR MUNICIPAL CORPORATION KOLHAPUR
Detailed Tender Notice No.: 66

The Commissioner Kolhapur Municipal Corporation Kolhapur invites online bids from eligible bidders who fulfills the conditions mentioned under this RFP Document, for management and operation and caring outvarious activities **Management, Operation and maintenance etc.**, at Sangetsurya Keshavnar Bhosale Natyagruh details of which are given below.

a) The bid document will be available on the website from 28/08/2026 to 10/09/2026 up to 1700 Hrs. The Pre-bid conference of bidders may be convened on 02/09/2026 at KMC main Building Bhauisingh Road Kolhapur on 12.00 pm.

b) Last date and time for submission of Bids is 10/09/2026 up to 1700 pm and the technical bids will be opened (on line) on 10/09/2026 at 17.00 pm.

c) KMC reserves right to reject any or all the Bids and or the right to hold or withdraw from or cancel the Bidding process at any stage up to the final selection.

d) The interested bidders shall note that after publication of this tender notice, any further information in the matter of this bid process, including the corrigendum, CSC/CSD will be available on the above mentioned website only. <https://mahatenders.gov.in>

Sd/-
Additional Commissioner (I)
Kolhapur Municipal Corporation

Date: 28/08/2026

SR. NO.	NAME OF DEPARTMENT	NAME OF WORK/ NOTICE/ TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE	AMOUNT/ EMD (APPROX.) IN LACS	NODAL OFFICER / CONTACT / EMAIL
1.	Director Technical Education and Industrial Training Punjab Chandigarh	Supply of tools/ equipment/ Machinery/ Welder (GMAW & GTAW) & CNC Machining Technician Trades in different ITI's	31/08/2026 14/09/2026	18.56 Lac	9888337415 machinery.dti@punjab.gov.in
FOR FURTHER INFORMATION AND CORRIGENDUM & ADDENDUM IF ANY, KINDLY VISIT: https://eproc.punjab.gov.in/ , www.punjabitis.gov.in					RO Number: 1001/12/202 6-27/14672

পলাতক আসামির সন্ধান চাই

Ref:- West Agartala Women PS case No-2026 WAW 025, UFS-351(2)/351(3)/78/78/77 BNS & 12 of PCO&SO Act & Sec. 67 (B) of Information Technology Act, 2000, dated- 29/06/2026.

পাশের ছবিটি শ্রী বিশাল তরুণেন্দ্র, পিতা- শ্রী নিবারণ তরুণেন্দ্র, ছদ্ম ত্রিকানা- সোলেখি, গোপালপুর, চিই আসাম, বানা- বাজারিছড়া, জোলা-কাছার, আসাম এবং বর্তমান ত্রিকানা- শেরবিসানহাঙ্গি, সাকরা গুয়ার্ড হাসপাতাল রোড সাইড, শিমিমেব মন্দিরের নিকট, বানা- বোহাদুর্, ব্যাসালোর। অফিস-এর ত্রিকানা- ইকোপেস, স্টুট গার্ডেন, আউটার রি: রোড, কনটাক। উপরে উল্লেখিত যেকোনো অসুবিধা করার পর পলায়ন করেছে।

উপরে উল্লেখিত যেকোনো পলাতক আসামির সন্ধ্যে কাহারো নিকট কোন তথ্য জানা থাকিলে নিম্নলিখিত ত্রিকানায় ও ফোন নাম্বারে যোগাযোগ করার জন্য অনুরোধ করা হল।

১। পুলিশ সুপার (পর ত্রিপুরা): ০৩৮১-২৩২-৩৪৯৬
২। সিটি কর্পোরেশন: - ৩০৩৩২৩৭৪১/ ১০০
৩। পশ্চিম আশ্রয়তলা মহিলা থানা: ০৩৮১-২৩৮-৫৪৫৪

ICA/D/880/26

১৫/ পুলিশ সুপার পশ্চিম ত্রিপুরা

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PUBLIC NOTICE

INDIAN SOCIETY FOR TECHNICAL EDUCATION
IIT Campus, Shaheed Jeet Singh Marg, Near Katwaria Sarai New Delhi - 110016

Election to various positions of ISTE viz. EC/ SMC /Section Chairman for the term 2027-31 are scheduled during Sep-Oct, 2026. Details regarding election process, nomination form and fee etc. are available on ISTE website www.isteonline.in
Returning Officer, ISTE Election

EDUCATIONAL

GENERAL

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform the General public/ Whosoever it may concern that my client **Mr. YS Ajay Gandhi** residing at #93, SFS, 6th B Cross Road, B Sector, Opposite Reliance Fresh, Yelahanka New Town, Bengaluru - 560 084 Intends/Propose to purchase the schedule property belonging to Mr. T.C. Sreerama S/o Late Chikanna residing at Tharabanahalli, Chikkajajala, Bengaluru, Karnataka 562 157 who represent that he is the absolute owner and having clear and marketable title to the schedule property. Any Persons, Firm, Institution including Financial Institution claiming to have any right/ title/ interest/claims or enforceable right in the schedule property either as the owner or in any other manner of objection for such alienation may lodge their objections with documentary proof within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice, with the undersigned, failing which it will be presumed that no valid claims and objections subsist and thereafter my client shall proceed to complete the sale transaction with owner referred above. Any claims or objections received after the specified period will be deemed waived and not binding on my client.

SCHEDULE PROPERTY
All that piece and parcel of the Immovable Property being residential vacant site bearing Property/Site No.199, 200, 207 & 208, Municipal CG Assessment No. 14, New BBMP 'B' Form Serial No. 84, Present BBMP E Khatha, EPID No. 1082480197, Situated at Maruthinagar, BBMP Ward No. 1, Anjanappa Layout, Yelahanka, Bangalore North Taluk, Measuring East to West (80*76.5)/2 Feet, North to South 35.5 Feet, totally Measuring 2777.87 Sq. Feet, bounded on:
East By: Road,
West By: Private Property,
North By: Site No. 201 & 209
South By: Site No. 198 & 208
PRAPUL K.S. Advocate,
#14/4, Guttebasaveshwara Nagar, Behind Vagdevi College, Hesaraghatta Main Road, Chikabanaswara, Bengaluru - 560 080.
prapulgowda.19@gmail.com
Mob : 9611969898

UNION TERRITORY OF JAMMU AND KASHMIR
OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER
PWD (R&B) DIVISION NAGROTA
SHORT NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Short e-NIT No. 63 of 2026-2027/Nagrota Dated 25-08-2026

For and on behalf of the Lieutenant Governor, Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir e-tenders are invited on **percentage basis** from approved and eligible Contractors registered with Union Territory of J&K, CPWD, Railways, MES and other State/Central Governments for each of the following works :-

S. No.	Name of Work	Name of Division	Advertised Cost (In Rs. lacs)	Cost of document (In Rs.)	Earnest Money (In Rs.)	Time Allowed for complete e-on	Time and date of opening of tender	Class of Contractor
1	Construction of Parking Shed For students at GDC Palours	PWD (R&B) Division Nagrota	13.24	600	2% of Advertised Cost	03 Months	(1300 Hrs) on or after 08-09-2026	A, B, C & D Class
2	Construction of drain in front of RMG International School, Jandial	PWD (R&B) Division Nagrota	20.00	600	2% of Advertised Cost	02 Months	(1300 Hrs) on or after 08-09-2026	A, B & C Class
3	Development of Workshop and Washing Station at Jammu Taxi Golf Course Sidra, Jammu. (Under Capex Budget 2026-27)	PWD (R&B) Division Nagrota	7.00	600	2% of Advertised Cost	02 Months	(1300 Hrs) on or after 08-09-2026	A, B, C & D Class
4	Construction of Drains, Tiles Path, Culvert Approach Road at Control Room Suntsar. (Under Wildlife Department).	PWD (R&B) Division Nagrota	30.00	600	2% of Advertised Cost	03 Months	(1300 Hrs) on or after 08-09-2026	A, B Class
5	Day to Day Urgent Maintenance of Various Block of Camp from Block No. A to L, by way of Repair to Doors (PVC Flush), Metallic frames, Windows shutters (Galved Wire Gases) including painting fitting, Renovation of Damage Plaster in Patches by way of Scraping and Distemper, Waterproofing of Sunken Slab, Repair of Bathroom and Kitchen by way of Replacing Damaged G.I.C.I Pipes, Sinks, Tiles, Fittings, accessories etc. of Migrant Camp Jugi from Block No. A to L at TRT Migrant Camp Nagrota	PWD (R&B) Division Nagrota	45.93	600	2% of Advertised Cost	Upto march 2027	(1300 Hrs) on or after 08-09-2026	A, B Class
6	Repair and Renovation of old building of AAM Kot (under District Capex Budget 2026-27) (SSY/Health Component) (3rd Call)	PWD (R&B) Division Nagrota	2.91	600	2% of Advertised Cost	02 Months	(1300 Hrs) on or after 08-09-2026	A, B, C & D Class

Position of AAA : Accorded.
The Bidding documents Consisting of qualifying information, eligibility criteria, specifications, Drawings, bill of quantities (B.O.Q), Set of terms and conditions of contract and other details can be seen/downloaded from the departmental website <http://jitenders.gov.in> as per below schedule :-

1	Date of Issue of Tender Notice	25-08-2026
2	Period of downloading of bidding documents	From 27-08-2026 to 07-09-2026 upto 1800 Hrs
3	Date, Time and place of pre-bid meeting	XXXXXXXXXX at XXXX Hrs. in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Nagrota
4	Bid submission Start Date	27-08-2026
5	Bid Submission End Date	07-09-2026 upto 1800 Hrs
6	Date & time of opening of Technical Bids (Online)	08-09-2026 on or after 1300 Hrs in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Nagrota
7	Date & time of opening of Financial Bids (Online)	To be notified after technical bid evaluation is completed

No :- EE/ND/2026-27/512-31
Dated :- 25-08-2026

DIP/J-8878/26

Executive Engineer
PWD (R&B) Division Nagrota

THE HINDU

DISCLAIMER: Readers are requested to verify and make appropriate enquiries to satisfy themselves about the veracity of an advertisement before responding to any published in this newspaper. THE PUBLISHING PRT LTD, the Publisher & Owner of this newspaper, does not vouch for the authenticity of any advertisement or advertiser or for any of the advertiser's products and/or services. In no event can the Owner, Publisher, Printer, Editor, Director/s, Employees of this newspaper/company be held responsible in any manner whatsoever for any claims and/or damages for advertisements in this newspaper.

CITY UNION BANK LIMITED
Credit Recovery And Management Department,
"NARAYANA", Administrative Office, No. 24-B, Gandhi Nagar, KUMBAKONAM - 612 001. Email Id: crmd@cityunionbank.com
Mobile : 9344303739 / Ph: 2402322, 2401622 / Fax: 0435-2431746

POSSESSION NOTICE (IMMOVABLE PROPERTY)
Whereas, the undersigned being the Authorised Officer of City Union Bank Ltd., having its Administrative Office at **No.24-B, Gandhi Nagar, Kumbakonam - 612 001. and one of the branch offices at C - 9/115, Sector 8, Rohini, New Delhi, New Delhi - 110085 - New Delhi Rohini Branch**, under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13(2)&(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued a demand notice dated **08/05/2026** calling upon the borrowers **No.1/M/s. Karan Traders, (Represented by its Proprietrix Mrs.Harmeet Kaur)** 105, B D Chambers, D.B.Gupta Road, Delhi Cantonment, Delhi-110005 **No.2. Mrs.Harmeet Kaur, W/o. Gurmeet Singh, B-997, Shastri Nagar, Near Hanuman Mandir, North West Delhi, Delhi Municipal Corporation (u) - 110005 Also at, Mrs.Harmeet Kaur, W/o. Gurmeet Singh, No.26-C, Second floor, Block-I, Sector-18, Rohini Residential Scheme, Delhi-110085. No.3. Mr Gurmeet Singh, S/o. Mohan Singh, B-997, Shastri Nagar, Hanuman Mandir Wali, Gali, North West Delhi, Near Mother Dairy, Delhi Municipal Corporation (u)-110052 Also at, Mr.Gurmeet Singh, S/o. Mohan Singh, No.26-C, Second floor, Block-I, Sector-18, Rohini Residential Scheme, Delhi-110085 to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being **Rs.23.32,778/- (Rupees Twenty Three Lakh Thirty Two Thousand Seven Hundred and Seventy Eight Only)** within 60 days from the date of the said notice with subsequent interest thereon from **04/05/2026** with monthly rests.**

The borrowers above named having failed to repay the amount despite the receipt of the above referred statutory notice, NOTICE is hereby given to the borrowers above named and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him under section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said Rules on this **25th day of August 2026**.

The borrowers above named in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of City Union Bank Ltd., for an amount of **Rs.24,05,226/- (Rupees Twenty Four Lakh Five Thousand Two Hundred and Twenty Six Only)** and interest thereon from **24/08/2026** till the repayment of entire dues.

The borrower's attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

SCHEDULE OF PROPERTIES
Immovable Property Mortgaged to our Bank
SCHEDULE: A - Property 1 - Property Owned By Harmeet Kaur
Property Description: SFS Flat bearing No.26-C on Second Floor Block-I Sector-18, situated at Rohini Residential scheme Delhi, Delhi Municipal corporation (u) Delhi, Delhi Indian boundaries: North-East: Entry South-West: Open Below, North-West: Open / Staircase, South-East: Other Flat / Balcony

Place : Delhi
Date : 25/08/2026
Regd. Office:- 149, T.S.R. (Big) Street, Kumbakonam, Thanjavur District, Tamil Nadu - 612001. **CIN- L65110TN1904PLC001287.**
Ph: 0435-2402322, Fax: 0435-2431746 Website: www.cityunionbank.com

CITY UNION BANK LTD
Authorised Officer

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

S. Ramachandran
Mani Iyer Trading Co., Pollachi
Matto Tyres, Coimbatore
Passed away peacefully on
27th August, 2026.
Deeply mourned by
Maya Ramachandran
Sujini & Lakshmi
Sanjana, Shankar, Tasha & a big loving family.
Final rites on
30th August, Sunday.
Phone: 9840081651
(Messages Only)



THE KONGU VELLALAR INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY TRUST

Kongu Engineering College Campus, Perundurai, Erode, Tamil Nadu – 638 060

Founders' Day
CELEBRATIONS - 2026

Marching 50
TOWARDS
GOLDEN JUBILEE

29th August 2026 Saturday, 11.30 a.m.

Venue: Kongu Convention Centre, KEC Campus, Perundurai, Erode



Shri C. P. RADHAKRISHNAN

The Hon'ble Vice President of India

has graciously consented to be the Chief Guest
and unveil the plaque for

Arivukoodam ₹ 100 CRORE PROJECT
— A RESEARCH PARK —

@

KONGU ENGINEERING COLLEGE

தொட்டனைத் தூறும் மணற்கேணி மாந்தர்க்குக்
கற்றனைத் தூறும் அறிவு.

– திருக்குறள்

Just as water gushes forth in a sandy well as deep as you dig,
knowledge wells up in people as much as they learn and apply it.

- Thirukkural

OUR PRIDE



KONGU ARTS AND SCIENCE COLLEGE
— TRANSFORM YOURSELF —



KONGU POLYTECHNIC COLLEGE
— TRANSFORM YOURSELF —



KONGU NATUROPATHY AND
YOGA MEDICAL COLLEGE
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— TRANSFORM YOURSELF —

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Janani Climate Action Platform (JCAP), Tiruppur

Lotte India Corporation Pvt. Ltd., Chennai



MacDermid Alpha Electronics Solutions, Chennai

Milky Mist Dairy Food Limited, Perundurai, Erode

Saint Gobain India Pvt. Ltd., Perundurai, Erode

SKM Group of Companies, Erode

URC Construction Pvt. Ltd., Erode

VMC Steel and Alloys Industry, Perundurai, Erode

INBRIEF



Schoolchildren tie *rakhi* on PM Modi on Raksha Bandhan

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday greeted people on Raksha Bandhan and expressed hope that the auspicious festival brings happiness, prosperity, and success to everyone's lives. Continuing the annual tradition, schoolgirls visited the Prime Minister's official residence at 7, Lok Kalyan Marg, where they tied *rakhis* on his wrist. Mr. Modi shared photos and a video on Instagram showing the children tying *rakhis*. In the video, he was seen warmly interacting with the young visitors, shaking hands, and high-fiving with them. PTI

Even Ravana didn't deceive sisters like BJP, says Akhilesh

Samajwadi Party (SP) chief Akhilesh Yadav on Friday said even Ravana did not deceive his sisters the way BJP has, as he alleged that the Uttar Pradesh government failed to honour its promise of free bus travel for women on Raksha Bandhan. Mr. Yadav shared a video clip on X showing a mud-filled bus depot in Prayagraj, with people purportedly struggling to find buses on Raksha Bandhan. He claimed that women across the State on Friday complained about the unavailability of buses, lack of seats, and buses not stopping at the designated points. The former Chief Minister added, "The BJP may spread as much mud as it wants now, its lotus will not bloom. The BJP will go, and will never come back again." PTI

Bihar Board to replace 'fail' with 'eligible for skills' on Class 10, 12 marksheets from coming year

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

The Bihar School Examination Board (BSEB) will replace "fail" in Class 10 and 12 marksheets with "eligible for skills" from next year, Education Minister Mithilesh Tiwari announced on Friday, saying failure to score the expected marks in an exam does not diminish a student's talent.

The Education Department would soon issue directives to the BSEB in this regard, he added.

"The State government wants to protect students' morale. An exam score does not define a student's overall talent or potential. So the Bihar Examination Board would state '*kaushal ke liye patra*' (eligible for skills) instead of 'fail' on their marksheets," said the Minister.

He added, "Students tak-



Education Minister Mithilesh Tiwari said failure to score expected marks does not diminish a student's talent. FILE PHOTO

ing supplementary examinations for Class 10 will receive special classes for one month to help them prepare better and to ensure success."

Many students welcomed the announcement.

"Yes, removing the word 'fail' will do a lot of good. It is such a demeaning word. There is a social taboo attached to it," said Harshu

ing the water crisis.

The State Urban Development and Housing Department had entrusted BUIDCO (Bihar Urban Infrastructure Development Corporation) with a ₹70.34-crore comprehensive rejuvenation and beautification plan for three historically interconnected large ponds – Hara-hi, Dighi, and Gangasagar – covering 1.8 km. The corporation had even started work to lay pathways.

Plea in apex court

Apprehending that the plan would "alter the ecological character of the wetland system that plays a vital role in groundwater recharge, flood moderation, and biodiversity conservation", the TBA members petitioned the Supreme Court seeking restoration and reclama-

Kumar, who is due to appear for his Class 12 exams in February next year.

Standing next to him outside a coaching centre in Patna's Kankerbagh area, another student, Ishu Kumar, termed it a "big boost" to students' morale.

The announcement comes a day after the government agreed to conduct the Teacher Recruitment Examination-4 in a single phase, following which aspirants who had been protesting in the State capital's Gardanibagh area called off their agitation.

Teacher support portal

As per sources, Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary is likely to launch a "teacher support portal" at a Teachers' Day event on September 5 in Patna, under which one teacher from each district would be honoured with a State-level award.

tion instead of beautification of the ponds.

They filed a writ petition on March 14 in the Supreme Court. The Division Bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta recorded an oral undertaking from the Bihar government on July 28 that "no further soil would be dumped" in the three ponds and that the ongoing beautification plan will be halted thereafter. "The court also sent a clear message that ponds and water bodies cannot be encroached upon or filled under the guise of beautification," a TBA member said.

The apex court later fixed September 7 as the next date of hearing.

"We will wait for the final order of the Supreme Court in this matter and then take a decision under the allocated funds under



West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari holding the tricolour as he sings *Vande Mataram* at Jadavpur in Kolkata on Friday. ANI

rival groups. The university has set up an inquiry panel to probe the matter and multiple FIRs have been registered in connection with the incident.

"What freedom do you want? Freedom to consume heroin, ganja and drugs? Freedom for the *tukde-tukde* gang?" the Chief Minister said, denouncing slogans of "azadi (freedom)" raised by a section of students.

"What *azadi* do you want? '*Kashmir Mange Azadi*'?" he said.

According to the Chief Minister, students of the university took out rallies not in favour of the country but for stopping the war during Operation Sindoor. "Go write 'Free Pakistan-occupied Kashmir' first. It is ours and it must be returned," he said.

'They or we will stay'

Issuing a stern warning to the students, whom he described as "ill mannered", the CM said it is a "final reckoning". "Either they will stay, or we will. There

will be nothing in between," he said.

Mr. Adhikari also made references to Nandigram and Jangalmahal and claimed that in the past he had freed these areas of Communists and Maoists respectively. Describing himself as someone who can "clean garbage", he said, "I know the ailment and also the medicine."

He threw a challenge to the Jadavpur University Teachers' Association and said students cannot hide behind the group. He recalled an earlier visit to the university when he was the Leader of the Opposition and a student had died following an alleged case of ragging. He said some people jumped onto his vehicle and when questioned they replied: "We are Maoists. We have come to tell you to go back."

A few days ago, the Chief Minister had called for an inquiry into alleged 'anti-national' graffiti and posters that surfaced in the boys' hostel of the university's Arts unit.

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

The Kolkata police registered FIRs against Trinamool Congress general secretary Abhishek Banerjee and Rajya Sabha MP Derek O'Brien on Friday for allegedly assaulting police personnel and obstructing them from discharging their duty when they went to remove an electric signboard of the party at a building in Kolkata's Camac Street area. Three FIRs have been registered in connection with the scuffle.

"The removal was being done as per the direction of the Kolkata Municipal Corporation (KMC). At least 13 people have been arrested in the case so far. All three complaints by the police personnel and KMC officials have been reported at the Shakespeare police station," Additional Commissioner of Police Kunal Ag-



Trinamool Congress MP Abhishek Banerjee. FILE PHOTO

garwal said.

Mr. Agarwal said the accused included party leaders Mr. O'Brien, Mr. Banerjee, Humayun Kabir, and Baiswanor Chattopadhyay.

"These leaders, along with their supporters, formed an unlawful assembly, obstructed, and restrained the police personnel and KMC officials from entering the common area and discharging their lawful duties, and used criminal force and assault against police personnel," the officer said.

Press Trust of India
AHMEDABAD

A reading session of Nobel Peace Prize winner Malala Yousafzai's memoir, *I Am Malala*, turned violent in Gujarat's Ahmedabad after a group of people identifying as right-wing activists attacked the participants, police said on Friday.

The police have arrested three persons in connection with the attack that occurred at Vastapur Garden on Thursday evening, an officer said.

Vastapur police station Inspector G.M. Chaudhary said a group of nearly 20 people, including women, gathered at the public garden for the reading and were confronted by an armed group of 18 to 20 individuals, claiming to be from the Bajrang Dal and Vishva Hindu Parishad (VHP), over their choice of

Ready to resign as MLA for Statehood, says Puducherry CM

Rajesh B Nair
PUDUCHERRY

When the Statehood issue came up for discussion for the second consecutive day in the Puducherry Assembly on Friday, Chief Minister and AINRC founder N. Rangasamy went to the extent of offering to resign from his MLA post to fight for the cause.

"I am ready to resign my MLA post, and if there is an assurance that Statehood will be given, we can go to Delhi to take up the demand with the Central government," the Chief Minister said, as members raised the issue of Statehood during the general discussion on the budget in the Assembly.

The response came after BJP legislator A. John Kumar said the demand for Statehood might not be feasible and, hence, the Assembly should request the Central government to accord 'Special Category Status' to Puducherry.

'Won't try tactics'

"The BJP will try tactics with other State governments but not in Puducherry, because of the respect the BJP high command has towards our Chief Minister. The Chief



Chief Minister N. Rangasamy

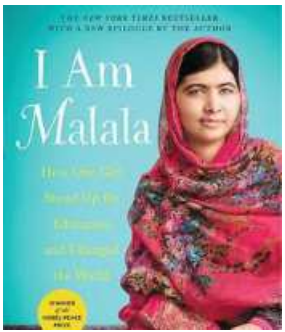
Minister should go and meet the Prime Minister and make the request. If he makes the request, the Prime Minister will concede to the demand," Mr. Kumar said.

Intervening, Pro-tem Speaker A. Anbalagan said the BJP MLA should not create confusion as the Assembly has passed several resolutions unanimously urging the Central government to accord Statehood to Puducherry.

As the legislators were speaking on the subject, Mr. Rangasamy intervened to reiterate his demand for Statehood. The administrative problems faced by Puducherry could only be solved by obtaining Statehood, he said.

After the CM spoke, Mr. Anbalagan urged the members to speak only on the budget proposals during the discussion.

Group attacks reading session on Malala Yousafzai's book in Ahmedabad; three arrested



The attackers demanded to know why participants read Yousufzai's memoir. FILE PHOTO

book. The officer said when the readers were leaving the garden after the session, the armed group arrived and demanded to know why they had read Ms. Yousufzai's memoir.

An altercation ensued, leading to a scuffle in which two people were injured; the attackers were armed with sticks, the official said. "An FIR has been

registered, two of the accused were known to the victims. Apart from them, six individuals have been identified, and three have already been arrested," the officer said.

The attackers claimed to be affiliated with the Bajrang Dal and the VHP, the officer added.

A few weeks ago, a private school in Ahmedabad was forced to drop books by Ms. Yousafzai and Holocaust victim Anne Frank from its mandatory reading list after protests from right-wing groups.

'Incurable disease'

Meanwhile, Congress leader Pawan Khera on Friday took a swipe at right-wing activists who assaulted participants of the book reading session, saying "ignorance, combined with a dash of communalism, is an incurable disease".

'City of ponds': Darbhanga residents wade into legal battle to save water bodies

Amarnath Tewary
DARBHANGA (BIHAR)

Darbhangha in Bihar's Mithilanchal region, about 160 km north of State capital Patna, had over 350 ponds till 1969 as per the district gazetteer and was known as the 'city of ponds'. Today less than 100 remain and the town is grappling with depleting groundwater, leaving residents struggling to draw water from hand pumps in summer.

The remaining ponds are allegedly being filled up daily and built over by encroachers to construct houses, hotels, hospitals and coaching institutes, according to members of Talab Bachao Abhiyan (TBA), a citizen group. They add that the State government's "rejuvenation and beautification" plan for historical ponds is deepening

ing the water crisis.

The State Urban Development and Housing Department had entrusted BUIDCO (Bihar Urban Infrastructure Development Corporation) with a ₹70.34-crore comprehensive rejuvenation and beautification plan for three historically interconnected large ponds – Hara-hi, Dighi, and Gangasagar – covering 1.8 km. The corporation had even started work to lay pathways.

Plea in apex court

Apprehending that the plan would "alter the ecological character of the wetland system that plays a vital role in groundwater recharge, flood moderation, and biodiversity conservation", the TBA members petitioned the Supreme Court seeking restoration and reclama-

tion instead of beautification of the ponds.

They filed a writ petition on March 14 in the Supreme Court. The Division Bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta recorded an oral undertaking from the Bihar government on July 28 that "no further soil would be dumped" in the three ponds and that the ongoing beautification plan will be halted thereafter. "The court also sent a clear message that ponds and water bodies cannot be encroached upon or filled under the guise of beautification," a TBA member said.

The apex court later fixed September 7 as the next date of hearing.

"We will wait for the final order of the Supreme Court in this matter and then take a decision under the allocated funds under



Work on the Bihar government's beautification plan halted at the Gangasagar pond on directions of the apex court. AMARNATH TEWARY

the scheme. Funds allocated for the beautification plan of the ponds will not go waste in any condition. In such cases, we use it for another scheme," State Urban Development and Housing Department Minister Nitish Mishra told *The Hindu* on August 26.

The TBA, formed in

2012, has about 150 members. Leading the fight are its convener Narayan Jee Choudhary, known as the 'pond man' of Darbhanga; Vidyannath Jha, a founding member who is a retired principal and Botany professor at Lalit Narayan Mithila University; and activists Taseem Nawab and

Ajit Kumar Mishra.

They allege that the beautification plan under the BUIDCO "violates the Wetlands (Conservation and Management) Rules, 2017, and judicial directions governing the protection of wetlands and water bodies by the National Green Tribunal (NGT)".

'Nature's storage tanks'

According to former State Pollution Control Board chairman Ashok Kumar Ghosh, ponds are "nature's storage tanks". "During monsoon, ponds hold excess rainwater and allow it to seep into the ground, replenishing underground aquifers. Once ponds are filled and paved over, the natural recharge system is lost and rainwater flows away through drains or evaporates instead of filtering into the soil," he said.

Mr. Ghosh added that the problem has become acute with depleting groundwater in fast-growing towns like Darbhanga where demand for drinking water has led to "heavy dependence on borewells as natural recharge zones continue to disappear".

This is not the first time that the TBA has protested against encroachments. "We have organised dharnas thrice from Darbhanga to Laheriasarai, taken out rallies twice, conducted signature campaigns, and held *nukkad* (street corner) and all-party meetings to raise the issue but nothing happened. We then decided to petition the NGT, which too passed directives in our favour. Finally, we approached the apex court when the government started its beautification plan," Mr. Mishra said.

Mr. Nawab, in his 60s, claimed that he faced a "murderous attack" on January 10, 2024 for opposing encroachment of the Moin pond. He alleged that he had filed a complaint at the Laheriasarai police station on January 13, 2024, but no action was taken.

"After our legal interventions, the State government has stopped landfilling around these three ponds that are ecologically sensitive wetlands. Both the Supreme Court and the NGT have issued directions to prepare a comprehensive digital inventory of ponds and wetlands across Bihar, including Darbhanga. And by doing this, we can save these three ponds of Darbhanga as well. These directions will strengthen monitoring and conservation of ponds," Mr. Choudhary said.

Nepal floods: four bodies found in U.P. river; deluge threat looms over Bihar

Ganga, Gandak, Kosi, Burhi Gandak rivers in spate; bodies drift into Indian territory following floods in neighbouring country, authorities in contact with Nepal administration to ascertain their identity

Press Trust of India
MAHARAJGANJ (U.P)/PATNA

Four bodies were recovered from a river in Uttar Pradesh's Maharajganj district after they apparently drifted into Indian territory from Nepal amid the ongoing flood situation, officials said on Friday.

The bodies were found in a severely decomposed state and have not yet been identified; they are currently being held at the mortuary of the Maharajganj district hospital.

Authorities are in contact with the Nepal administration to ascertain their identities and check whether they could be among those reported missing after the floods and landslides.

District Magistrate Gaurav Singh Sogarwal said the flood threat has subsided as the water flow in the river has decreased, and added, "The situation in the area is



People moving to a safer location from the flood-hit Nakta Diyara area following a rise in the water level in Ganga river, in Patna on Friday. PTI

normal at present." Officials said efforts were under way to identify the deceased and ascertain whether they were among those missing in Nepal following the devastating floods.

Maharajganj shares a border with Nepal and the district administration had earlier sounded a high alert

following the flash floods in the neighbouring country. River levels and water bodies receiving water from Nepal have been under continuous monitoring, with vulnerable villages and low-lying areas kept under watch.

The administration also appealed to residents to stay away from rivers and

low-lying areas and made arrangements for evacuation if water levels rose sharply.

Meanwhile, parts of Bihar faced the threat of a deluge as water levels in the Ganga, Gandak, Kosi and Burhi Gandak rivers showed a rising trend following the devastating flash floods and rains in neighbouring Nepal.

A senior official here said that excess water brought in by the flash floods has caused the Gandak river to swell, forcing authorities to open all 36 gates of a barrage over the river in Valmiki Nagar. Around 1.02 lakh cusecs of water were released from the Gandak Barrage by 5 p.m. on Friday. "Teams of the Water Resources Department at the Gandak barrage are on alert," the official said.

The National Disaster Response Force and State Disaster Response Force have been kept on standby at certain locations.

Campus on edge: ongoing stir at IIT Delhi places spotlight on student suicides, mental health

Ashna Butani
NEW DELHI

Unprecedented scenes have unfolded at one of India's most prestigious engineering institutions – the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT), Delhi – over the past week, following the death by suicide of an MSc student.

Classes have been largely called off, and students have been holding a sit-in where the student died last week. Never has the institute witnessed agitation and student mobilisation at this scale.

"Every death is followed by a copy-paste e-mail from the administration, following which the campus is almost immediately expected to go back to normal, even as memorials are held for those who died on the campus," said a student who wished to remain anonymous.

On the boil

This "pent-up frustration", the student added, blew up when students who had seen the 31-year-old's body were called for classes soon after in the Lecture Hall Complex, the very



IIT-D has never seen a stir with such a large turnout. FILE PHOTO

spot where the death had occurred. A comment from an administrative official that the student was "beyond repair" further angered the students.

The administration responded by setting up an external probe committee, which was reconstituted following objections from the protesters, and providing financial assistance to the family, though the amount has not been specified. The institute is yet to comment on allegations over the "insensitive remarks" following the student's death.

On Thursday, IIT Delhi said the academic load had been lightened significantly since 2025, with lower credit loads in the first semester, smaller classes to minimise stress, fewer

weekend exams and flexible credit distribution.

To this, an IIT-D student, who has also studied at Delhi University and wished to stay anonymous, said, "The academic pressure is intense. Families don't understand why we can't give them time. Many of us have to pull all-nighters and function on one or two hours of sleep."

Mental health support

On the institute's assertion that students' well-being is supported by a 24x7 team of counsellors and psychiatrists, fully reimbursed external care and a swift emergency protocol, students said counselling is inaccessible or ineffective. "There has been no monthly roster of counsellors in the past year," said another student. In addition, the student said that parents are involved in such cases, raising privacy concerns.

A source at the institute countered this, saying the counselling centre is accessible and only minutes away from the hostels.

(Those in distress can contact Tele MANAS at 14416 to seek help)

Delhi Weather	max	min
Delhi City	36	28
Safdarjang	36	28
Palam	34	26

Delhi Palam Today
35°C The weather will be mostly dry. Day will be warm with uneasy afternoon. Night will be comfortable.

Delhi Palam Tomorrow
36°C The weather will be dry. Day will be very warm and uneasy. Night will be comfortable.

Timings		
DELHI		
SATURDAY, AUG. 29		
RISE	05:58	SET 18:46
RISE	19:24	SET 06:49
SUNDAY, AUG. 30		
RISE	05:58	SET 18:45
RISE	19:54	SET 07:48
MONDAY, AUG. 31		
RISE	05:59	SET 18:44
RISE	20:25	SET 08:47

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NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY E-TENDER NOTICE

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Tender Notice No. & Description
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Crime Branch to examine latest claims on Sukumara Kurup

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Sukumara Kurup, one of Keralam’s most infamous fugitives, is back in the news again after the Crime Branch recently took up the long-pending case.

Even as speculation was rife that the police were moving towards closing the case on the assumption that Kurup might no longer be alive, a Malayalam news channel aired an image of a man in Brunei, claiming it was a recent image of Kurup in hiding.

However, on Friday, a Thrissur man named Karunakaran Menon disputed the claim, stating that the photograph being circulated as Kurup’s is actually that of his brother Damodaran Menon. He claimed that his brother has been living in Malaysia for nearly three decades.

Retired police officer Ali Akbar had also claimed that Kurup was alive in Brunei and working in the construction sector.

However, Karunakaran Menon strongly disputed the identification of the photograph. He said Damodaran Menon had spoken to his relatives a few months ago, but they have been unable to contact him since the photograph began circulating.

‘Only rumours’

Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala on Friday said reports that Kurup is still alive were “only rumours” and directed the Crime Branch to verify their veracity.



Sukumara Kurup.

Crime Branch ADGP H. Venkatesh told *The Hindu* that the information shared by the news channel would be sent to Interpol for verification. An Interpol Red Corner Notice is already in existence in the name of Kurup. Mr. Venkatesh said the case will not be closed unless conclusive evidence is available that he is dead.

“... Since a former investigation officer who has previously looked into the case has also made some claims, his statement will also be recorded,” said Mr. Venkatesh.

Kurup’s crime

Kurup was allegedly inspired to stage his own death so that his family could claim a ₹50-lakh insurance policy. On January 22, 1984, Kurup and his accomplices were driving around looking for a victim with a similar physique when Chacko, a film representative, hitched a ride with them. Later that night, Chacko’s body was found in a burnt car on a farm near Mavelikara. Kurup has remained absconding since then.

Karnataka Minister resigns following graft allegations

Nagendra also announces his decision to resign as MLA, saying he had no role in the scam but was stepping down to avoid embarrassment to the govt.; the move comes as a shot in the arm for BJP

Nagesh Prabhu
BENGALURU

Planning and Statistics Minister B. Nagendra resigned on Friday over allegations of involvement in the embezzlement of funds from the Karnataka Maharshi Valmiki Scheduled Tribes Development Corporation Ltd.

The Minister announced his decision to step down at a press conference at the State secretariat. Mr. Nagendra said he had no role in the scam but was resigning to avoid embarrassment to the party and the government. He later submitted the resignation formally to Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar, who said he would take a



B. Nagendra addressing a press conference in Bengaluru before submitting his resignation on Friday. SUDHAKARA JAIN

call on it on Saturday in consultation with the party high command.

Mr. Nagendra also announced his decision to quit the membership of the Karnataka Legislative Assembly and challenged the BJP to face him in the Balla-

ri Rural Constituency.

Mr. Shivakumar, who had earlier described Mr. Nagendra as a “disciplined soldier of the party”, told reporters later in the day that Mr. Nagendra had resigned because he was hurt and not because he

was guilty. The BJP’s campaign for his resignation, he said, showed their intolerance of a Dalit’s ascent to power. He also said that the Governor had written to him regarding prosecution proceedings, and he would consult the legal experts in this regard.

Mr. Nagendra’s resignation has come as a shot in the arm for the Opposition BJP which had come under attack from its own cadre as well as the Central leaders for failing to take any campaigns to a logical end.

Opposition leader R. Ashok and State president B.Y. Vijayendra have remarked that Mr. Nagendra’s resignation is not the end, but the beginning of their campaign.

Police fined for illegal arrest in Karnataka

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The Karnataka High Court has imposed an exemplary cost of ₹3 lakh on a sub-inspector (SI) and his two superior officers – an Assistant Commissioner of Police (ACP) and a Deputy Commissioner of Police (DCP) – for illegally arresting a man in an alleged case of fraud in the execution of a will, having a history of over three decades.

The court penalised the police after noting that the petitioner, K.N. Mohan

Reddy, an attesting witness to the disputed will, and arraigned as accused under Sections 61, 338 and 340(2) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, was arrested nearly 48 hours before the deadline set by the investigating officer for him to appear before the police.

The court observed that Sunil Kumar K.R., a sub-inspector attached to the Whitefield Police Station in Bengaluru, had issued a notice under Section 35(3) of the BNSS on August 25, directing the petitioner to appear before him on Au-

gust 27 at 11 a.m. However, instead of allowing the petitioner an opportunity to comply, the police arrested him from his residence on the very day the notice was issued.

Safeguard disregarded

“This turns the statutory safeguard on its head,” the High Court said.

It also observed that “the notice under Section 35(3), which ought to have operated as a shield against unnecessary arrest, was rendered a mere piece of paper by the very authori-

ty that had issued it.”

A higher officer cannot remain a silent spectator while a subordinate treats a statutory safeguard as dispensable paperwork and thereafter seeks shelter behind the individual act of the investigating officer, the court observed while imposing costs on the sub-inspector and on his superior officers.

The court made it clear that the costs should not be paid from the public exchequer, but would have to be borne personally by the three officers.

Sena upset over CM’s ‘unilateral’ decision to relax Marathi rule

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
MUMBAI

Leaders of the Shiv Sena, a constituent of the ruling Mahayuti in Maharashtra, expressed displeasure on Friday with its ally BJP over Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis’s “unilateral decision” to relax Shiv Sena leader and Transport Minister Pratap Sarnaik’s drive to ensure that commercial autorickshaw and taxi drivers speak “functional Marathi”.

Mr. Sarnaik had announced in April that autorickshaw and taxi drivers must display basic knowledge of Marathi and set a deadline of August 15 to comply with the rule. After drivers’ unions opposed the move, Mr. Fadnavis on Thursday announced that the government would give drivers one year to learn the language and not take any action for non-compliance during this period.

“The CM should have taken us into confidence. Now, there is a perception that he was the one to give relief to north Indian drivers,” a Sena leader said.

Party leaders said they were also unhappy at celebrations organised by migrant drivers at a few places in Mumbai after the decision.

“Why do you need 12 months to answer 12 simple questions in Marathi?” said a party leader.

“It is the Shiv Sena’s core ideology to stand for Marathi *asmita* (pride). We were the ones who decided to implement this rule,” a Sena leader said, adding



Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis. FILE PHOTO

that the party will not move away from its core ideology though there is a clash with the BJP over it.

Taking a dig at the Shiv Sena over these differences, Opposition Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Sanjay Raut said it was time for the Shiv Sena to rebel.

“The party’s decision was changed by the BJP. The Transport Minister does not hold any power. The leader of that party is [Union Home Minister] Amit Shah. So, his orders will have to be followed. That is exactly what has happened,” he said.

BJP sources said the decision was taken in view of the 2027 Uttar Pradesh Assembly election.

‘Interference in work’

Shiv Sena sources indicated that the unrest in the regional party was not just over the issue of Marathi, but alleged interference in the functioning of the party’s Ministers by the BJP. “All our Ministers are unhappy as they are not being allowed to function properly. Our decisions are superseded, even overruled by the BJP,” a Shiv Sena leader said.

INBRIEF



Will ensure representation of backward sections: Satheesan

The Keralam government will conduct special recruitment if it is found that marginalised sections do not have adequate representation in government service, Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan said in Thiruvananthapuram on Friday at an event marking the 163rd birth anniversary of social reformer Ayyankali. The government will examine recruitment made through the Kerala Public Service Commission every three years. Mr. Satheesan also said the ruling UDF government will strive to find solutions to the backwardness faced by Dalit Christians in the State.

₹424-crore drinking water project unveiled in Ongole

The Andhra Pradesh government has undertaken the AMRUT 2.0 scheme at a cost of ₹424.42 crore to ensure round-the-clock drinking water supply to the residents of Ongole, Human Resource Development Minister Nara Lokesh has said. Mr. Lokesh laid the foundation stone for a major drinking water project at Rangarayudu Cheruvu in Ongole on Friday. “Megha Engineering & Infrastructures Limited is set to complete the project within two years...” the Minister said.

Keralam agriculture dept. revamps local committees

The Department of Agriculture in Keralam has revamped the Agriculture Development Committees (ADC) at the levels of the Krishi Bhavan, the urban and rural local bodies and the districts. It noted that the Agriculture Director had recommended the reorganisation on the basis of a revised set of guidelines. Apart from monitoring agricultural activities, the duties of the ADC include collective action in times of natural calamities, assessment of the availability of organic fertilizers and farm sector credit. The local panchayat chief serves as the chairperson of the 23-member Krishi Bhavan-level ADC.

Ready for launch



A view of the feeder canal of Pula Subbaiah Veligonda project ahead of its inauguration in Markapuram, Andhra Pradesh on Friday. K.V.S. GIRI

Drive flags inflow of spurious liquor into Keralam’s Ernakulam

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Excise department claimed to have identified continued flow of spurious liquor into the Ernakulam district of Keralam despite repeated crackdowns.

The agency registered 131 cases in the district under the Abkari Act from August 1 to 27 over alleged illegal manufacturing, sales and trafficking of liquor during the special enforcement drive during the Onam season.

The highlight of the special drive, according to Excise officials, was the reported seizure of 1,248

litres of illicit spirit from Kothakulangara in Angamaly in the first week of the month. Two persons, Santosh, 57, of North Paravur and Ratheesh, 40, of Kollam, were arrested in connection with the seizure. It followed the reported confiscation of nearly 7,000 litres of spirit from Payyannur, according to the officials.

The traffickers were reportedly planning to bottle and sell it as Indian-Made Foreign Liquor (IMFL) by diluting and adding colour to it. The target customers were those from the low-income groups, an official said.

Two-year-old girl becomes stem cell donor for brother with thalassemia

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

A two-year-old girl became a blood stem cell donor for her elder brother with thalassemia, giving him a chance at a healthier life.

Som was just five months old when he was diagnosed with thalassemia major. His younger sister, Saumya, was later diagnosed with the same condition. Neither had a full Human Leukocyte Antigen (HLA) match within the family, leaving them dependent on regular blood transfusions.

For the family, which lives in a small village in Korba district, Chhattisgarh, and faced financial



India’s genetic diversity makes finding a compatible unrelated donor particularly challenging.

difficulties, arranging blood and medicines every month was a constant challenge.

The family’s circumstances changed after Khushi, their third child, was born in 2021.

Kumaraswamy calls for Priyank Kharge’s exit over KPSC row

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Union Minister H.D. Kumaraswamy on Friday accused the Karnataka government of allowing IAS officer Gyanendra Gangwar, who was the Controllor of Examinations of the Karnataka Public Service Commission (KPSC) when alleged irregularities occurred in the recruitment of Assistant Executive Engineers (Grade-I), to “run away”. He also demanded the resignation of Home Minister Priyank Kharge over the matter.

At a press conference in Bengaluru, Mr. Kumaraswamy alleged that Mr. Gangwar “disappeared” following Enforcement Di-

rectorate (ED) searches, and questioned the circumstances surrounding it. He also alleged that Mr. Kharge was “protecting” the officer despite allegations against him. “He disappeared as soon as the ED conducted searches. What is the connection between the disappearance and the Home Minister?” Mr. Kumaraswamy asked.

Mr. Kumaraswamy, who released investigation records, OMR sheets and other documents at the press conference, alleged large-scale manipulation in the recruitment of Assistant Executive Engineers conducted when Mr. Kharge was Minister for Rural Development and Panchayat Raj.

er challenge in treating thalassemia. More than 10,000 children are estimated to be born with thalassemia major in India every year, according to the DKMS Foundation India. Patients with severe forms of the disorder require regular blood transfusions, while transplantation requires a suitable donor match.

India’s genetic diversity makes finding a compatible unrelated donor particularly challenging, said Patrick Paul, executive chairman, DKMS Foundation India. He added that only 0.09% of Indians in the relevant age group were registered as blood stem cell donors.



BJP national vice-president Ram Madhav in conversation with The Hindu's Political Editor Nistula Hebbar at The Hindu MIND event. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

‘BJP’s challenge is the BJP itself’

The party has grown bigger in the country not just in terms of its electoral or organisational footprint but also its ideological influence, says its national vice-president; he claims the RSS is the biggest challenger to the Congress ideology today and that singling out Hindu texts while ignoring the Koran and the Bible reflects anti-Hindu bias; he adds that Statehood will be restored in J&K as promised by the Prime Minister and the Union Home Minister

INTERVIEW

Ram Madhav

The newly appointed national vice-president of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), Ram Madhav, has worn many hats, from Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) spokesperson in the early 2000s to party general secretary in charge of States like Jammu and Kashmir and Assam, head of the conservative think tank India Foundation, and foreign policy commentator. He shares his views on the challenges facing the party, Gen Z protests, and India's relations with its neighbouring countries in a wide-ranging conversation at The Hindu MIND event moderated by Nistula Hebbar. Edited excerpts:

You returned to the BJP organisation after a break, having first joined it at the start of the Narendra Modi government's first term. What challenges does the organisation face now, after 12 years as the ruling party?
We always see the challenge to BJP as the BJP itself; where we are today and where we have to reach next year. In politics, you will have a number of contemporary issues to tackle and a number of challenges that come up from time to time. Sometimes it can be so-called Gen Z protests, sometimes it can be a challenge posed by the Opposition, but the real issue is how we go from this year to next year, this election to the next election, and this general election to the next general election. Looking at that, I would say the BJP continues to grow as the most important political organisation in the country. I don't think there is any challenge for the BJP. In 12 years, the BJP has grown and grown bigger in this country, not just in terms of its electoral or organisational footprint but also its ideological influence, and its reach in the country. It has grown very big.

You are an out-and-out RSS man. This is also the centenary year of the RSS, the BJP's parent organisation, but it also seems to have walked into a perfect storm of the Ayodhya donation embezzlement case and the moral implications of it. How do you view what has happened and how do you think the RSS can extricate itself from it?
In the centenary year, that's not exactly how you should look at the RSS. What happened at the Ram Temple was a minor aberration that was immediately addressed. This was not something to do with the RSS per se, but with the management of the temple, of a lacuna in the day-to-day donation management. I would only like to say that it was the result of an oversight, an aberration, which was immediately identified and is being very seriously addressed. The people accountable for the issue accepted moral responsibility and stepped down. A new CEO is being appointed. But that is not the prism through which the centenary of the RSS should be viewed. Started by a former Congress person, Dr. [Keshav Baliram] Hegdewar, in 1925, it is, 100 years down the line, today the biggest challenger to the Congress ideology. It has grown into the most formidable challenger to that world view because of what happened between 1925 and 1947 - or I would say since 1950, the first 25 years of independence - it created such an important ideological divide within the Congress. One section, what we call in our terminology Nehruvian ideology, had its day for the first three or four decades in the country. And as for the other stream of the independence movement, of which the RSS was also a part, the RSS ideology has become the most dominant thought process in this country.

Another major development in the last few



As far as we [BJP] are concerned, we are guided by the Constitution of India; it is our *smriti* (code) today

months has been the Gen Z protests. How do you see the BJP handling this?
We are creating many categories nowadays, there is Gen Z, Gen Alpha. For me, this is the youth of our country and their aspirations have to be addressed. We understand that there are certain concerns. Those are not just limited to the NEET exam. It was an immediate trigger for whatever happened. We are dealing with a country where more than half of the population is below 35 years. Obviously, as a political party, we have to keep that in mind while picking office-bearers and deciding our agenda. That's why today the BJP has a president who is in his mid-40s. A lot of youngsters have found a place in the team in important positions. And you would have already read in the papers that right from Ministers in the government to functionaries in the party, we are, in a big way, engaging with the youth of the country. We will be reaching out to them in universities, colleges, and other places. There will be continuous engagement with them. We consider it as one of our priorities.

There was also a feeling that, in terms of social media, the medium of outreach to this particular cohort was kind of missed by the BJP and its social media communication. Also, the tonality of some of its interventions on social media did not go down well with young people.
Look, there are two things I would mention here: number one, it's always easy for those in the Opposition to use all platforms to attack the government. When we were in the Opposition, we also used it very effectively as you only have to criticise. As an Opposition, you only have to create a meme and throw it. Secondly, remember, social media is algorithm-driven. I mean, if you are able to generate sufficient content, then it continues to generate content on its own through algorithms. So, if there are 10 memes that get so much amplification that they will start influencing people, it means that for every 10 memes I should be able to produce 20 memes as the ruling party to counter that effect. Our team tried its best to tackle this challenge. But it's a competition. Social media is the most democratic media in the country, everybody has space on it.

You have also been one of the founders of a think tank in the conservative space, the India Foundation. What was the reason

behind venturing into that realm? And do you think you have been successful in framing a pedagogic structure pertaining to your ideology?

Not many people know that the India Foundation came into existence in 2009. Over the last 15 years, it has created a place for itself in the think tank world. We felt that there is a need for this kind of intellectual engagement. For example, within the country and outside, there is a big section of intelligentsia that wants to engage with our movement. They may not come to our day-to-day *shakha* (branch), the RSS day-to-day activity, but when it comes to the thought process, they are ready to align with us. For such intelligentsia organisations, the India Foundation definitely helped as a good platform. There was no existing right-wing intellectual ecosystem in this form. There are a few other think tanks that were created by like-minded people. I think they have served a great purpose in creating a strong 'right-wing ecosystem' in the country.

Speaking of ecosystems, the Prime Minister has said the country should be aware of a category called 'dimagi Naxals'. What do you think he meant by that?

To put it simply, it is what the United Progressive Alliance government under (Dr.) Manmohan Singh told the Supreme Court in an affidavit: that certain intellectuals in this country are more dangerous than those Naxals who are in the forests, in the jungles. 'Dimagi Naxal' means those who are supporting this kind of idea intellectually - through intellectual forums, intellectual platforms, their writings, speeches, and other articulations. So, that is basically what he meant as I understand it.



Congress leader Rahul Gandhi quoted the Manusmriti and made a call to 'smash the patriarchy'. The BJP's response was to term him 'anti-Hindu'.

The *Manusmriti* is an old scripture that contains many things. The stanza quoted by Mr. Rahul Gandhi was there, no doubt, but it also states that if a woman is unhappy in a marriage she can separate, it gives four situations for opting for separation. What is important, however, is to remember that the

Manusmriti was a moral code at that time, alongside at least 12 other such codes. No king in India ever made any of these *smritis* their Constitution. As far as we are concerned, we are guided by the Constitution of India; it is our *smriti* today. I don't want to create a religious discourse, but aren't there similar provisions about women in the Koran and the Bible? If you quote only from one set of scriptures, you will be blamed and called anti-Hindu. Why isn't Rahul Gandhi quoting from other scriptures too to make the point about discrimination against women? That's because Rahul Gandhi has an agenda. Nobody agrees with that proposition (a specific *sloka* in the *Manusmriti*); our track record reflects it. It is the NDA (National Democratic Alliance) government that nominated a tribal woman to be elected as the President and [brought] relief to Muslim women via the triple talaq Act. Look at Rahul Gandhi's father Rajiv Gandhi's record in terms of women's rights: when the court granted relief to Shah Bano, it was his government that brought in a law to overturn that. So, when Rahul Gandhi quotes

from only one scripture, he will be questioned on his selectivity and what it says about him and his commitment to women's empowerment.

How do you evaluate the developments in Jammu and Kashmir since Article 370 was revoked? It has been seven years since it was made into a Union Territory and there have been demands that Statehood should be restored. What is your view on that?

First of all, the question is not about restoration. The erstwhile State was split into two Union Territories (UTs). The residual UT, what is today J&K, needs to be granted Statehood. This residual UT will get the full Statehood as promised by the Prime Minister and the Home Minister in Parliament. Now, when will it happen? Why seven years? Let me ask you a counter question then. Article 370, which was abrogated seven years ago, was introduced as a temporary provision yet it remained in place for 70 years. If a temporary provision can remain there for 70 years and you happily enjoyed that status, why can't you wait for Statehood for a few years? Nobody is asking you to wait for 70 years. It has only been seven years now. It will be given to the people of J&K, the current UT. The appropriate time is for the government of the day to decide.

You are also quite well-versed in the politics of our neighbourhood. Why does it feel like India is under siege from its neighbours, except possibly the Taliban in Afghanistan?

First, that is not true. We have very good relations with several of our neighbours, including Sri Lanka, Bhutan, and Nepal. One country with which we have never had a good relationship with is Pakistan. Now, those who know about the trajectory of our foreign policy in the last six to seven decades know that this kind of situation has existed in our neighbourhood all the time. When regimes changed, we faced challenges, new situations, and new equations. We are seeing that kind of situation in one or two countries in our neighbourhood. In the case of Pakistan, especially since 2008, we have not had good relations. In between Prime Minister Modi tried to improve it for a couple of years, but then we realised that it was not going to happen because of the mindset there. But there were periods when we had good relations with them also in the last 50 years.

On a philosophical note, which political belief of yours has changed the most over the years?

I really don't think any of my core political beliefs and commitments have changed over the years. I have always been fully committed to India's democratic system. I always believe that is the only way India can really grow and progress. My only difference, probably, with some people from within the larger ideological family that I belong to is that sometimes I tend to take a slightly middle path kind of approach. That's my temperament, I don't like to take any extreme positions and for that I faced certain consequences. Since you talked about the formation of the [BJP-Peoples Democratic Party coalition] government in J&K, yes, there was strong opposition to it in my own ecosystem. But then there was a given political situation, which prompted us to take that stride, and we did it. It is not the first time, if you look back at the Samyukta Vidhayak Dal (SVD) governments in 1967, in eight States, there were some where both the Jana Sangh of those days and the Socialists, and in one or two cases even the Communists, were part of the same government. At that time also, this was a big question: how can you share a bed with Communists or Socialists? In fact, someone told me the story of how one famous person had told [Pandit] Deendayal Upadhyaya about the consequences of the SVD governments: 'Chaku karbuja par gire, karbuja chaku par gire, katega to karbuja hai' (Whether the knife falls on the melon or the melon on the knife, it is the melon that gets cut). That whether you go with ideological rivals or they go with you, you will be the victim. Then I had to explain to him, 'No, there should not be any political untouchability, you have to be pragmatic and all that.' Remember V.P. Singh's government? V.P. Singh refused to share the dais with BJP leaders during the [1989] campaign, but afterwards we worked with him for one and a half years. So, certain political situations ask you to take some kind of middle path. I am a believer in the middle path. That also has not changed over the years.



BJP national vice-president Ram Madhav being presented a memento by Varghese K. George, The Hindu's Resident Editor, New Delhi. S. Ramanujam, The Hindu's Assistant Vice President, Finance Administration, is also seen. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR



Scan the QR Code to watch the full interview



Unkind cuts

The scale of ECI's deletions in Telangana and Karnataka needs explanation

The Special Intensive Revision (SIR) process being conducted by the Election Commission of India (ECI) is increasingly leading to a clear case of disenfranchisement in several parts of India. Marauding on after a judgment by the Supreme Court of India allowed it to proceed, the SIR has now struck out a fifth of the names from the electoral rolls in Telangana and Karnataka – nearly 22% and 19.5% respectively – and among the highest in the country. The cuts are steepest in their capital cities – five constituencies in Bengaluru have lost more than half of their electors while nine of Hyderabad's 15 have seen deletions of more than 40%. Cuts of this kind cannot simply be a trimming of bloated rolls at the margins. If they are accurate, the ECI's own summary revision processes were yielding bloated rolls in recent elections, and doing so in the very places with high net in-migration from the rest of India. And if the deletions are to be justified, those struck off the rolls must have left the States – a move within Karnataka or Telangana would only relocate a voter's name on the same State roll, not remove it altogether. Yet, this is neither borne out by recent survey data nor by the government's own population estimates.

During the Bihar SIR, the Court asked why political parties had filed so few objections, seeking inclusion of wrongly deleted names; that question might hold true for the Southern States as well. A plausible reason could be that the voter id is useful to a citizen only once in a few years, leading to less alacrity on their part. This may explain why a process that puts the onus on electors yields cuts of this scale. Meanwhile, proving a smoking gun in the data is difficult because of the ECI's opacity. It has not published the elector-to-population ratio for any State so far during the revision even though doing so is mandatory and is the only test of under-enrolment. The Karnataka Chief Electoral Officer has not even bothered to release a gender-wise breakdown of the deletions, instead scattering the lists across several Google Drive links without the old booth numbers, making verification arduous. The outcome of such shoddiness is visible in West Bengal, where the ECI's dubious "logical discrepancy" process disenfranchised lakhs of electors, forcing them to seek redress before tribunals set up under the aegis of the Court. Months after the elections, records obtained under a Right to Information request show that barely 82,000 of the nearly 38 lakh appeals before the 19 tribunals have been decided, with more than 90% of those decisions favouring electors seeking restoration. The ECI – an institution once envied even by wealthier democracies for bringing large numbers of Indians to the polling booth – is now an obstacle to universal adult franchise.

Deferred rivalry

Injuries are coming in the way of anticipated matchups in the US Open

The Carlos Alcaraz-Jannik Sinner rivalry is no doubt this era's defining matchup, but it has also been punctuated by long pauses. In early 2025, Sinner was absent for three months as he served a doping-related ban; this season, Alcaraz was out of action for four months from mid-April owing to a troublesome wrist. Just when it seemed that the two leading lights will come face to face at the US Open starting Sunday, Sinner has been waylaid by a knee injury. In 2025, they met six times in six months; there has just been a solitary duel in the subsequent nine. In a way, the postponement of the battle may suit Alcaraz, for the seven-time Major champion has not played a competitive singles fixture since Barcelona in April. The Spaniard has warmed up for Flushing Meadows with two mixed doubles matches partnering the legendary Serena Williams, but a best-of-five-sets contest is a significant step-up. The 23-year-old will open against Roman Safiullin – a tricky player who beat Alcaraz in 2023 on a Paris hard-court and reached the Wimbledon fourth round this year – and is drawn to meet the in-form American Ben Shelton in the quarterfinal. Potential semifinal opponents include 24-time Slam titlist Novak Djokovic and 2021 US Open winner Daniil Medvedev, which makes the defending champion's path challenging.

However, Djokovic and Medvedev are on their own tough journeys. The 39-year-old Serb is no longer the once-renowned hard-court master, and lost his lone match - in Cincinnati - after the semifinal reverse to Sinner at Wimbledon. Medvedev was last in a Major final at the 2024 Australian Open and is without a trophy since February. Alexander Zverev thus has a golden opportunity to make his big breakthrough on his favourite surface. Without Sinner, the German will be the top seed, and following the French Open triumph and Wimbledon runner-up finish, the 29-year-old will be confidence personified. Among women, two-time defending champion Aryna Sabalenka would have liked to be that player, but the Belarusian World No. 1 has wobbled of late and seen her lead at the top cut to less than 450 points. Her chief challenger Elena Rybakina may be racing against time to recover from an ankle injury, but with Iga Swiatek, Coco Gauff and Jessica Pegula all in impressive form leading into New York, Sabalenka will have a daunting task. Wimbledon winner Linda Noskova will be looking for a worthy follow-up while the fast-rising 21-year-old from the Philippines, Alexandra Eala, will hope to continue her recent eye-popping run. With Serena and Venus Williams set to pair up in doubles, there will be a rich sprinkling of stardust too.

For a people long regarded as at the crossroads of civilisations, the past five years of the Islamic Emirate of Afghanistan (IEA) under Taliban rule resemble the backwaters. After 47 years of bloodletting, terrorism and foreign occupation, the current “stability” is a respite. But the ongoing time-freeze only postpones an eventual transition to modern universality. So far, the process has been glacial and selective, causing pain and uncertainty. It is time to take stock of the past half-decade and try to fix the broad contours of a foreseeable future.

A more stable country

The IEA's overall performance since the August 15, 2021 takeover has been a binary. On the positive side, though the IEA 2.0 transition was as chaotic as the IEA 1.0 transition in 1996, it spared the country from mass retribution. Afghanistan is now largely stable and secure. The country's “Badlands” were long associated with militant groups such as al-Qaeda. Their 9/11 attacks unleashed two decades of bloody U.S. retribution on both al-Qaeda and the IEA 1.0. The IEA 2.0 has disallowed the use of their territory for operations against other countries. During the past five years, an estimated 5.7 million refugees from Pakistan and Iran have returned to Afghanistan. While this return of an eighth of the country's population has exacerbated the penury, the government has managed it reasonably well. These unmistakable shifts from the ruinous policies of the previous Islamic Emirate (1996-2001) have partially mitigated the world's concerns.

But many of the IEA 2.0 domestic policies are a carbon copy of IEA 1.0; its socio-political contrast with the preceding western-designed Republic was widely perceived as a huge regression. To the universal abomination, Taliban 2.0 swiftly reinstated the harshest rules in the contemporary Islamic world: a ban on music, no education for girls beyond class six, gender segregation, lifting the ban on child marriages and a narrow power base shutting out women, non-Pashtuns and ethnic minorities. The Taliban theocrats defended these measures, citing Islamic Sharia, Sunni Deobandi Islam, Hanafi jurisprudence and Pashtun traditions.

The West, in particular, felt deeply betrayed by the Taliban's cynical disregard for their commitments under the transitional accord signed in Doha in 2020 to pave the way for U.S. and North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) troop withdrawal. Two decades of the U.S. military campaign against the Taliban, which caused 6,379 deaths and cost \$2.26 trillion in expenses, now seem in vain. Despite intense Pakistani lobbying for the IEA 2.0 to be accepted and formally recognised, there was global unanimity to withhold both till such draconian policies were moderated. The global community's response to the Taliban's re-takeover was framed by the United Nations



Mahesh Sachdev

Retired Indian Ambassador, specialising in West Asian and oil issues

A fortnight ago, the Taliban completed five years in power, bringing stability; but Afghans still yearn for a political, economic and social makeover

Security Council resolution 2593 adopted on August 30, 2021. It demanded, *inter alia*, that Afghan territory not be used for terrorism and that human rights, including the rights of women, children, and minorities, be upheld. It also encouraged all parties to seek an inclusive, negotiated political settlement, with the full, equal, and meaningful participation of women, that responds to the desire of Afghans to sustain and build on the gains Afghanistan had made over the preceding 20 years, in adherence to the rule of law. Five years on, this resolution remains a cornerstone of global policy on the IEA.

The IEA 2.0's political architecture of an uncodified unitary theocracy evolved informally from the Quetta Shura, later called Rahbari Shura. It received the endorsement of 3,000 Afghan clerics and tribal leaders under the aegis of a Loya Jirga (Grand Assembly) held in Kabul in mid-2022. Accordingly, Hibatullah Akhundzada was appointed Supreme Leader (Amir al-Mu'minin), with combined powers as head of state, commander-in-chief, and religious leader of Afghanistan. He heads the 26-member Leadership Council, the IEA 2.0's top decision-making body, which includes Prime Minister Hassan Akhund and three Deputy Leaders. Its decisions are implemented by the Cabinet. The IEA 2.0 has often cited the Holy Koran as its Constitution and Hanafi jurisprudence as its common law.

Fragile economic progress

The latest available figures are tentative, but point to a relative improvement in the Afghan economy. Draconian measures have curbed rampant corruption and smuggling. Thanks to better fiscal discipline, the national currency, the Afghani, is stable. Consumer inflation was 2% in 2025. The Nominal GDP is \$19.66 billion, contributed by services (49%), agriculture (26%), manufacturing and mining (13%) and construction (12%). Its growth rate for 2025 was 4.3% and is expected to be 2.3% in 2026. The country's GDP dropped by nearly 20% following the Taliban's return to power. The GDP/capita is only \$448, less than one-sixth of India's.

Nearly half of Afghanistan's 49 million population lives under the national poverty line, facing acute food shortages. Still, most western official development assistance (ODA) remains suspended, and many multilateral agencies restrict their funding. Some non-governmental organisations have continued to help mitigate the dire situation. The population rose by 11% in 2025, largely due to immigration. This led to a 4% decline in GDP per capita despite healthy economic growth. Afghanistan has a Human Development Index (HDI) score of 0.496, among the world's lowest. Formal unemployment is put at 13.3%, with most women and a quarter of young men jobless. While foreign trade reached \$13.9 billion in 2025, Afghan exports barely cover 15% of its imports. Despite a rise in tax revenues, negligible foreign investments and declining

A shared disaster, beyond borders and geopolitics

On Wednesday, August 26, 2026, at approximately 8.44 a.m. Nepal time, what initially appeared to be a 4.4-magnitude earthquake struck near the Nepal-China border. It triggered the collapse of an enormous glacial slab, which plunged a kilometre below to the valley floor, resulting in devastating flash floods. The United States Geological Survey later confirmed that the seismic activity was, in fact, the glacial collapse itself and the landslide (later registered as equivalent to an earthquake measuring 5.2) rather than by tectonic shifts. Preliminary estimates suggest that 579 people have perished in Nepal, with nearly 2,000 people missing, many of them believed to be foreigners.

Entire villages and towns that this writer has previously travelled through have been swept away. Vital infrastructure, such as bridges and hydropower stations, has been completely decimated. A staggering 475 megawatts of generating capacity has been wiped off Nepal's electricity grid. This may go down as the most devastating natural disaster Nepal has ever witnessed.

Nature's fury knows no borders

For Nepal and its two neighbours, India and China, which ordinarily see themselves caught up in geopolitical contestations in the country, the catastrophic force of Mother Nature is a reminder that the political dimensions of geography are relevant only insofar as nature does not intervene, unexpectedly and destructively. The natural world does not recognise political boundaries in the same way that the custodians of nation-states do. China and India both suffered substantial losses from Wednesday's floods. Human and property losses continue to mount in all three countries, including Nepal.

China's Gyirong Port, the largest land trade



Bhaskar Koirala

Nepali scholar based in New Delhi and the founder of the Nepal Institute of International and Strategic Studies, which launched the first Nepal-India-China Trilateral Track II Dialogue in 2014

For Nepal, India and China, the devastating cross-border floods are a stark reminder of nature's fury, and that cooperation must transcend the boundaries of geopolitics

port in the Tibet Autonomous Region and the primary gateway between Nepal and China, was designated an international-standard land port. An upgrade in August 2017 led to its transformation, upgrading it from a bilateral crossing to a fully recognised international gateway.

Built at a cost of \$175.8 million, the port and the services it provided are now effectively buried beneath heavy sediment and debris.

Access roads on the Chinese side leading to the Nepal border, as well as power supplies and local communication links, have been completely severed or severely damaged. There are reports of fatalities on the Chinese side – a number that is almost certain to rise. There are also reports of people missing in Tibet's Gyirong County, including foreign nationals.

The loss of human life for India is tragic, with the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) confirming that Indian nationals are missing or untraced. Most of them were tourists-cum-pilgrims headed to the abode of Lord Shiva at Kailash Mansarovar. This is a route this writer has travelled on more than a few occasions. The pilgrims would have driven from Kathmandu through the lush, rocky and distinctly narrow river valley to reach Gyirong Port, before proceeding further upwards to the majestic Tibetan Plateau.

Flood fallout for India

For India, the downstream flood threats to its States have been severe, although the immediate threat from some of these events may have passed. Floodwaters reached the Gandak, Kosi and Ganga rivers in Bihar, prompting authorities in Patna to go on maximum alert and deploy large teams, particularly to the Valmikinagar Barrage and along vulnerable embankments, to monitor alarmingly high water levels. Riverside

external grants leave the government with insignificant funds for welfare or decrepit infrastructure mauled by nearly five decades of instability. After the formation of IEA 2.0 in 2021, the U.S. froze \$9.6 billion worth of Afghanistan's foreign assets.

During the past five years, the IEA 2.0 has sought international acceptance and legitimacy without undertaking the necessary domestic reforms. Nevertheless, the ostracising consensus has frayed, and realpolitik has spurred engagement. The IEA now claims to have 40 active diplomatic missions abroad and more than 20 countries represented in Kabul, even as Russia is so far the only country to have recognised the IEA and opened an embassy in Kabul. Pakistan, China, Iran and India have established links with Kabul at variously nuanced *de jure* levels without extending formal recognition. Some trade and mineral exploitation transactions have also been made. Iran, the Central Asian Republics, the Gulf countries and Türkiye have extended trade and logistical links. With the solitary exception of neighbouring Pakistan, with which it is in conflict, Afghanistan's links with most regional countries are stable.

New Delhi's Afghan engagement

India was initially sceptical of the IEA 2.0, but has since come full circle. New Delhi continues to conform to global norms by not having full diplomatic recognition, without preventing substantive bilateral engagement. Following the Afghan Foreign Minister's successful visit to India in October 2025, three other Afghan Ministers have also visited India. Despite Pakistan's denial of overland transit, India-Afghan annual trade has hovered around one billion dollars, with India becoming one of the largest markets for Afghan exports. India has provided the IEA with valuable humanitarian assistance. Indian mentoring has improved the Afghan cricket team's performance.

With five years of governance behind them, some IEA leaders are beginning to see the unsustainability of their headline domestic socio-political agenda. For instance, the Taliban now claim that the ban on higher education for girls is due to a lack of funds for segregated education. The need of the hour now is for the world community to encourage this trend. It should collectively come up with a critical mass of incentives to gently induce the IEA to reform.

As South Asia's trendsetter, India is well suited to match mutual expectations and create a pathway for normalisation of IEA 2.0, preferably through a multilateral donors' conference. Ironically, five years ago, Pakistan tried to get the world to accept the IEA 2.0. It failed because the Taliban, then flushed with victory over the U.S., saw no need to adopt. In case India decides to take up this “great game”, New Delhi would need to gingerly begin at both ends. A progressive and moderate Afghanistan, thus created, would be an asset not only to India but also to the world at large.

communities were evacuated to safer locations. Authorities in Uttar Pradesh also went on alert, with the State's Relief Commissioner tracking developments in real time, as overflowing rivers from Nepal naturally flow into Indian territory.

Border districts such as Maharajganj and Kushinagar stepped up emergency surveillance and deployed emergency personnel. India's National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) deployed teams across the Bihar-Uttar Pradesh border area. New Delhi also activated an extensive Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief programme. The Indian Air Force dispatched more than 47.5 tonnes of emergency relief material to Nepal, including medical supplies, rations and tents.

A case for cooperation

All of this underscores how severely this calamitous event has affected all three countries – Nepal, India and China. The question that arises, therefore, is how to transcend some of the parochial features of geopolitics, while by no means ignoring the compulsions of realpolitik, and create a feasible framework for collaboration and coordination.

There is little doubt that Nepal, India and China will need to effectively address increasingly unpredictable cross-border natural phenomena such as the one we have just witnessed. There is equally little doubt that such events are likely to recur in the future.

The past few days have underscored the need to find ways to compartmentalise the harder political dynamics of the China-India-Nepal relationship and create space for cooperation when confronted with events that remind us of the fickleness of nature, the fragility of human life, and the physical interconnections that inextricably link the three countries.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

A climate frontline

The disturbing pictures emerging from Nepal and the affected regions show the enormous destruction caused by end-glacial lake outburst floods (EGLOFs) and other extreme natural events. Rising temperatures, melting glaciers, erratic rainfall and environmental degradation are increasing

the vulnerability of the Himalayan regions. Stronger climate policies, sustainable development, protection of forests and rivers, and disaster-preparedness measures are essential. Nepal and its neighbours must act collectively before nature sends even stronger warnings. **Md Sabir Hussain**, Arrah, Bihar

The devastation has exposed the vulnerability of communities living in one of the world's most fragile mountain ecosystems. It is a grim reminder of how rapidly natural disasters can turn into humanitarian catastrophes. The immediate priority must be rescue, relief and rehabilitation. Saving human lives, however,

requires moving from disaster response to disaster prevention. Countries sharing these mountains and glaciers — India, China, Pakistan, Nepal and Bhutan — should coordinate to keep people safe across borders. India and China, in particular, must demonstrate that saving human lives and protecting the environment

can transcend political differences. **Gregory Fernandes**, Mumbai

The disaster has prompted explanations, including avalanches, earthquakes, Chinese dam releases, western disturbances, intense rainfall and glacial lake outbursts. Determining the precise cause will

require rigorous scientific investigation, although political considerations and inadequate reporting may complicate the assessment. The broader lesson is clear: ecological disruption can intensify natural hazards. **R.S. Narula**, Patiala, Punjab

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

GROUND ZERO



Senior deputy president, Kandela khap panchayat, Raghubir Bhardwaj (standing), holding a meeting with fellow members, to finalise the agenda and fix duties for the Khap Sammelan, which was held in Jind district, Haryana, on August 9. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Old rules, New rebels

Haryana's khap panchayats have issued diktats against love marriages within a village cluster or clan, and live-in and same-sex relationships. If people do not abide by these, they will be barred from entering their villages, the khaps say. This has drawn strong opposition from Gen Z on social media. A section of the youth, both women and men, say the personal choices of consenting adults trump community custom. And that laws, rather than elderly men, protect women, reports **Ashok Kumar**

Anchal, an M.A. student and a resident of Igra village, Jind district, posted a video on social media satirising khap panchayats, the powerful but unelected community bodies dominated by elderly men from landowning communities in Haryana. Imagining what a “Gen Z panchayat” might look like, she suggests in the video that elderly men face restrictions on playing cards, smoking hookahs and *bidis*, and wasting time, while tobacco sellers be fined. The money collected through such fines, she jokes, could be used to replace phones damaged or confiscated from girls.

Anchal was responding to a controversy that exploded after a khap panchayat member, Virender Dhull, a resident of Ikkas village in Haryana, made a remark about young women at the Naugama khap meeting in Jind on August 1. The comment that went viral was about women riding pillion with their fathers on two-wheelers, their legs astride, while using mobile phones and wearing clothes the khap thought unsuitable. He said their phones should be smashed. Dhull, a director of physical education at Jat Senior Secondary School in Jind, was hit by social-media criticism.

Over the past few weeks, several khap panchayats across parts of north Haryana have unleashed a series of resolutions, many against women. The khaps have opposed marriages within the community and live-in and same-sex relationships, while also resolving to fight drug abuse, online betting, and obscene social-media content.

Khap leaders insist they are not issuing diktats. They describe themselves as community elders offering guidance to the youth, and argue that their goal is to preserve social cohesion and protect families. Except, ostracisation will be a penalty for those who disregard these social rules. And the rules are targeted primarily at young women.

To many, especially the social-media-vocal Gen Z, the khaps’ message sounded like an attempt to regulate their personal choices in the name of tradition.

“Why are concerns over culture and social behaviour directed primarily at girls? If these restrictions are genuinely meant to protect society and preserve our culture, they should apply equally to men,” Anchal says.

Young women see the controversy as an enduring culture of social control over female agency, and have posted videos against the diktats. Several men too, like rapper Rahul Fazilpuria and content creator Paras Yadav, too, took to social media to condemn the resolution.

Naugama khap president, Jaivir Lohan, however, says Dhull’s remarks have been misrepresented. He maintains that the khap has not banned mobile phones for girls or prescribed what women should or shouldn’t wear. Parents, he says, should decide what is appropriate for their children, and the khap will intervene only if parents seek its help. “The views expressed during the panchayat on women’s clothing and use of mobile phones was an individual’s opinion,” Lohan says. The Naugama khap has 42 members, all male.

Haryana’s over 130 khap panchayats have long carried an image of being stuck in time. Their decisions have frequently been criticised for restrict-



Why are concerns over culture and social behaviour directed primarily at girls? If these restrictions are genuinely meant to protect society and preserve our culture, they should apply equally to men

ANCHAL
Resident, Igra village, Jind district, Haryana

ing women’s autonomy, particularly their freedom to choose whom to marry, who to associate with, and how to live. They have largely kept women away from decision-making roles.

Khap state of mind

On August 9, 24 khap panchayats met in Jind’s Kandela village. Here, they passed a resolution disallowing women and men from marrying within the same *gotra* (clan) or cluster that their khap panchayats oversee. This diktat is based on their belief that its members are one extended social family. However, people are free to choose who they marry beyond this boundary.

Chanderbhan Nambardar, a khap member, says people within this network are considered brothers and sisters, irrespective of caste differences and, in some cases, *gotra* distinctions. For the khap, therefore, a marriage within these prohibited social boundaries is seen as a relationship crossing what the community considers a kinship boundary. Lohan says that same-*gotra* marriages lead to genetic disorders and weak offspring, because of a common gene pool.

The consequences, if the khap panchayat is disobeyed, are severe. Nambardar says that if a woman and a man who come under the 24 khap panchayats disobey, they will not be allowed to enter the area under their community-appointed jurisdiction. He acknowledges that the khaps have no legal authority, though.

The khaps also passed a resolution banning live-in and same-sex relationships, and content they felt was obscene, while also urging the government to regulate marriage by choice, or love marriages, as they are called in India.

Raghubir Nain, president of the Sarvjatiya Binain khap, in Jind, says the panchayat did not oppose love marriages, but wanted them to take place with parental consent and within accepted social norms. He refers to live-in and same-sex relationships as a “*nai beemari* (new disease)” in society. The Naugama khap has made similar demands.

Naugama khap spokesperson Umed Jaglan says they want the government to examine the social consequences of live-in relationships, particularly where a married person leaves a spouse and children to live with another partner. The khap argues that such relationships can damage families and traditional social institutions.

Khap leaders also say women are being included more in decision-making now, through special assemblies and women’s wings aimed at addressing social issues.

On August 23 in Jind, the Naugama khap panchayat convened its first ever women-led mahapanchayat. They too passed resolutions against love marriages and live-in relationships, but also against dowry and gun culture. A 21-member committee will spread the word and ensure compliance.

At a mahapanchayat, held in July at the Meham Chaubisi Chabutra in Rohtak, participants adopted resolutions against drug abuse, online betting, obscene social-media content, and the glorification of guns online. The gathering also decided to eliminate the use of hookah at community functions – an especially striking move in a State where the hookah has long been a symbol of rural social interaction. The mahapanchayat was chaired by Chaubisi Khap president Subhash Goyat and attended by prominent local artists, including Ajay Hooda.

Khap leaders say these social issues they take up rarely receive the same attention as their positions on marriage and relationships. Nambardar argues the khaps are “guiding lights” for the youth.

Gen Z hits back

On her YouTube channel, Leena Sharma (leena yuvan7240) criticises what she describes the khap diktats, questioning how restrictions on women’s clothing, mobility, and behaviour can be imposed in the 21st century. She points out that women sitting astride a motorcycle is a matter of safety. She also questions khap resolutions, such as not allowing DJ music at weddings, asking why community bodies should dictate personal choices. Her larger argument is generational: cities may be changing, she says, but villages need to change too.

On Instagram, Garima (@garima.sees) talks about how the khaps were claiming that this was done to save “culture”, but it was just to control women. In a Reel with the caption “One of the reasons why Haryana is developing backwards,” she says the State grapples with one of the highest youth unemployment ratios and one of the lowest sex ratios in India. “Meanwhile, Haryana’s male youth is involved in drugs and crime, but no such panchayat is held for the betterment of these people. *Na unkey liye kuch ban kiya jaata hai, aur na unkey liye kuch rules banaye jaate hain* (Nothing for them is banned, nor are there any rules made for them),” she says on the video.

In the first four months of 2026, Haryana’s Sex Ratio at Birth plummeted to 898 girls for every 1,000 boys.

It’s not just women speaking against the diktat. Aman Kashyap, who holds a master’s degree in journalism from a university in Jind, asks, “When the Constitution grants girls equal rights, how can a panchayat decide to smash their phones or restrict their movements?” He calls these diktats illegal and contrary to fundamental rights, including the freedom of movement, expression, and privacy. He stresses that the views of a few khap members should not be seen as those of all of Haryana, noting that many students and their parents too had opposed the decisions.

Krishan Dalal, a Reel creator with nearly 27.8k followers on his Instagram account @iamkrishan7, clocked 747k views on his post on the subject. In the Reel with some mixed messaging, he says, “Actually, *ye buddhay hain gay* (Actually, these old men are gay),” adding that, “Before they die, they want to come out of the closet....” He also says, with some misunderstanding, “*Ye low testosterone mard ki pehli pehchaan hoye kare, ki jab ka-*

hin uska bas nahi chalta toh aurat ne sanskar aur sabhyachaar sikhane nikileya kare wo. (The first sign of a low-testosterone man is that when he cannot assert his authority anywhere else, he sets out to teach women about values and civilisation).”

Critics, however, point out that societal relationships are governed through individual rights and the law, rather than through community sanctions. A YouTube channel FlicksUnpacked has uploaded a Short under the title “Huge Decision by Haryana Khap on Love Marriages”. It addresses Khap members as “so-called dadajis (paternal grandfathers)”, accusing them of seeking attention and social-media fame.

The clip reflects a wider generational tension in Haryana and elsewhere: traditional community-based institutions continue to assert authority over matters of relationships and social conduct, while the youth increasingly uses digital platforms to challenge those norms and demand greater autonomy, equality, and individual rights.

Customs versus law

As they sit in a circle in a building set on 5 acres of land in Ramrai village, some of the men feel India’s laws must be in tandem with Haryana’s social customs.

“Couples entering into these relationships, which are against our social customs, are given security by law-enforcing agencies,” Jaglan says, referring to safe houses set up by the government to protect couples who have been socially ostracised and whose lives are sometimes in danger.

Jaglan says the Naugama khap has actively approached political and legal authorities seeking changes to the law. According to him, more than two years ago, a delegation first met then Haryana Chief Minister Manohar Lal Khattar, and later, in January 2025, met Union Law Minister Arjun Ram Meghwal. Among its demands were changes to the Hindu Marriage Act, 1955, restrictions on same-*gotra* and same-village marriages, and legal action against live-in and same-sex relationships. Jaglan says the delegation was assured that its concerns would be placed before the Union Cabinet, but that no further action or response followed.

The khap also demanded changing the legal marriage age for women, with Jaglan recalling that some members had proposed reducing it from 18 to 16. He also points to its history of approaching political and judicial authorities, including earlier meetings with former Haryana Chief Ministers Devi Lal and Bansi Lal, as well as a representation before the Supreme Court.

The khap leaders see matters such as drugs, guns, and dowry as being interconnected with other parts of the social order, like marriage and relationships. Their critics see a dangerous blurring of the line between community advice and coercion.

Anti-women accusations

Nambardar rejects the accusation that khaps are anti-women. He points to the wider political system to explain why women remain under-represented in khap leadership. “Women became sarpanches in Haryana only in the 1980s,” he says, questioning the gap between political promises and reality. “Every political party talks about 33% reservation for women, but how many women are actually in the State Assemblies and Parliament?”

According to him, the problem runs deeper than the khaps themselves. Indian society, he says, continues to be patriarchal, with women still under-represented in politics, government, and employment. “So naturally, there are fewer women in khaps as well. But their representation is growing fast.”

Nambardar argues that several decisions taken by khaps have received support from women. For instance, during the wrestlers’ protest, when several women wrestlers from Haryana had accused BJP leader Brijbhushan Singh of sexual abuse, the khaps stood by the women.

The khap remains rooted in a Haryana where village identity, kinship, honour, and collective decision-making continue to carry enormous weight. But it operates alongside Gen Z that is increasingly connected to cities, smartphones, social media, new forms of work and relationships, and a legal system built around individual rights. That collision is producing uncomfortable questions on both sides.

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Chanderbhan Nambardar with other members of the Naugama khap panchayat in Ramrai village, which oversees 21 villages in Jind district. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

From Page One

Publisher pulls memoir over ‘PM, RSS references’

Sources said that Ms. Gandhi’s manuscript ran into trouble at the stage of legal scrutiny, which has become a trend over the last decade.

When the legal team’s feedback to remove or alter the sections related to the PM, the RSS, and Ms. Gandhi’s opinion on India-China relations was communicated to the author, they were reportedly told that this is a story of her life, and she would not alter anything in the manuscript as self-censorship would interfere with the story-telling process.

Ms. Gandhi has been working on the book for several years and had consulted her close friends, including a few authors, in the process of her research and writing, *The Hindu* has learnt. Ms. Gandhi’s office has not commented on the matter.

The book, charting Ms. Gandhi’s journey from Italy to India, will be published for international readers on November 10, the book’s international publisher, Alfred A. Knopf announced on August 18. “In this revelatory book, the once famously reticent Sonia Gandhi opens up with warmth and candor to narrate her remarkable life, from her childhood in post-war Italy, to the romance that brings her to India, to the shattering losses that will reshape not only her own future but also that of her adopted home,” it said.

Under the present circumstances, the international edition will be available to Indian readers willing to buy the book.

Penguin India’s controversial record

This is not the first controversy that has thrust Penguin Random House India into the spotlight this year. It had been expected to publish former Army Chief Manoj Mukund Naravane’s memoir *Fours Stars of Destiny* earlier this year, but the book remained unpublished, reportedly over the author’s description of the standoff between Indian and Chinese forces at Galwan in 2021. Subsequently, hard copies of the book as well as digital copies of the manuscript became available and created controversy about its exact status. The publisher then asserted its rights over the material, saying that the “book has not gone into publication”. Graphic novelist Joe Sacco’s book, *The Once and Future Riot*, based on the Muzaffarnagar riots of 2013, was also pulled by Penguin Random House India, allegedly over the use of an “inaccurate” map of India.

IIP growth slows to 6.7% in July from June’s 8.8%

Industries such as beverages, wood, paper, and non-metallic minerals also supported this relatively high growth, Mr. Sabnavis said.

Rajeev Sharan, head of research at Brickwork Ratings, however, said the main 6.7% growth in the IIP might be overstating “the breadth of the recovery” as the underlying data shows a split in the way Indians are spending their money. That is, the data seems to suggest that expenditure on daily-use items is slowing while spending on durables seems to be doing well.

“The July numbers show a widening gap in household spending,” Mr. Sharan said. “Consumer durables, the big-ticket items such as vehicles and appliances, grew 10.5%, while everyday goods such as food and toiletries [consumer non-durables] fell 1%,” he added.

Mr. Sabnavis agreed with this assessment, and said non-consumer categories were likely to have driven the growth in manufacturing in July.

Mr. Sharan added that a similar split runs through factory output, with the motor vehicles sector up 22.2% and electrical equipment up 28.3%, while food products grew a much slower 2.6% and clothing contracted 0.6%. “This suggests discretionary and credit-linked purchases remain strong, while everyday items, more closely tied to rural incomes and real wages, remain weak,” Mr. Sharan said. “Headline IIP at 6.7% therefore overstates the breadth of the recovery.”

The data shows that the capital goods sector, which is typically associated with asset creation, grew 16.1% in July 2026, its fourth consecutive month of double-digit growth. In fact, the sector has grown in double digits in nine out of the last 12 months, despite a high base.

The infrastructure sector grew by 6.9% in July 2026 on a high base of 11.2% in July of last year. This was, however, down from 8.8% in June 2026.

The mining sector contracted 0.9% in July 2026 on a high base of 10.7% growth in July last year.

India signs deal with U.S. on procuring Javelin

Its fire-and-forget capability lets the operator fire the missile and move to another position without having to guide it throughout its flight.

The Javelin system is produced by the Javelin Joint Venture, comprising RTX and Lockheed Martin. Currently, the U.S. Army, U.S. Marine Corps and several international customers operate it. The U.S. Embassy said the signing would facilitate discussions on mutually beneficial co-production and create additional opportunities to strengthen the defence industrial bases of India and the U.S.

The procurement assumes significance in the backdrop of India’s efforts to rapidly strengthen its anti-armour capabilities following Operation Sindoor, while simultaneously deepening defence-industrial cooperation with the U.S.

Congress accuses publisher of bowing to Centre’s ‘pressure’

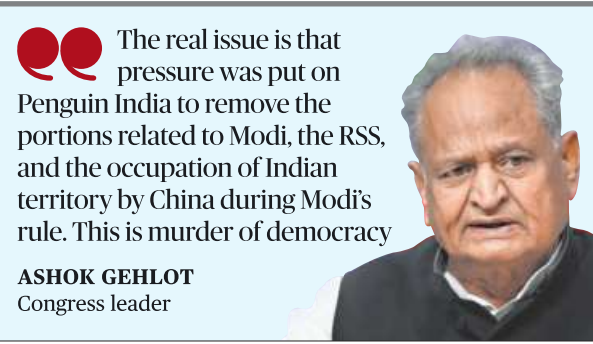
Party leaders question why publisher ‘wants to make changes’ to Sonia Gandhi’s memoir in India; they express ‘grave concern’, saying the matter raises questions regarding freedom of expression

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Congress leaders on Friday accused Penguin Random House India of giving in to pressure over the publication of former Congress president Sonia Gandhi’s memoir, *Belonging: A Journey of Love*, with senior party leader Ashok Gehlot alleging that the publisher sought to remove portions critical of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the RSS, and the alleged “occupation” of Indian territory by China.

The Congress reactions came after Penguin Random House India issued a statement, saying that “fact-checking and editorial recommendations” were part of its normal publishing process.

“Penguin Worldwide is ready to publish Smt. Sonia Gandhi ji’s upcoming book worldwide in its original form, but Penguin Random House India wants changes made to launch it in India. After all, what is



the reason or what pressure is there that what is being published across the world cannot be published in India?” Mr. Gehlot said in a post on X.

‘Murder of democracy’

He said Ms. Gandhi’s “integrity and dignity” in public life were exemplary and alleged that suppressing her book under pressure amounted to a “murder of freedom of expression”.

“The real issue is that pressure was put on Penguin India to remove the portions related to Modi, the RSS, and the occupation of Indian territory by China during Modi’s rule.

This is the murder of democracy,” he alleged.

Former Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Kamal Nath termed the publisher’s refusal to bring out the memoir in India a matter of “grave concern” and questioned whether the decision had been taken independently.

“Will the publisher decide what a senior figure like Mrs. Gandhi will write and what she will not? The question also arises whether the publisher is saying this on its own or if there is pressure from someone on it,” Mr. Nath said.

Congress deputy leader in the Lok Sabha Gaurav

Centre eases norms for defence exports, licences

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI



The Ministry says the steps will help Indian companies access international markets faster. FILE PHOTO

The Defence Ministry has simplified export and licensing norms to help Indian defence manufacturers access global markets faster.

Under the revised Defence Export Standard Operating Procedure (SOP), stakeholder consultation [with Ministries and government agencies concerned] has been dispensed with for exports of non-lethal defence items to most destinations. Safeguards, however, will continue to apply to sensitive countries.

The Ministry’s Department of Defence Production has also overhauled the Open General Export Licence (OGEL) framework, which provides eligible exporters a standing, one-time authorisation to self-generate export authorisations for multiple consignments of specified de-

fence items without seeking separate approval for every shipment.

Three existing OGEL SOPs covering major platforms and equipment, parts and components, and intra-company transfer of technology have been consolidated into a single framework.

The validity of OGEL has been increased from two to three years.

A new provision has been introduced for Indian companies having long-

term contracts or agreements with foreign original equipment manufacturers (FOEMs). An OGEL can be granted for eligible items for the particular FOEM, with validity aligned with the underlying contract or agreement, subject to prescribed conditions.

The range of items eligible for export under OGEL has also been expanded to include civil-end-use exports of specified components of small-calibre arms and protective equipment.

Delhi couple held for nexus with ISI espionage network

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi Police Special Cell arrested a couple from the city for allegedly working for Pakistan-based intelligence operatives and helping an ISI-backed espionage network procure Indian SIM cards and recruit people for reconnaissance of cantonment areas, officials said on Friday.

The accused, identified as Mohammad Sahil, 25, a resident of Sarai Kale Khan, and his wife, Sameera, 21, were recruited through social media and provided logistical support to Pakistani handlers, the police alleged. Two mobile phones containing incriminating conversations with Pakistani intelligence operatives were recovered from them.

The Special Cell alleged that the couple came in contact with an agent, who subsequently introduced them to a Pakistan-based intelligence operative.

The couple was allegedly tasked with providing logistical support to the network in Delhi, recruiting more individuals for espionage and carrying out field operations.

The Special Cell said the investigation began after its Northern Range unit received information about an ISI-backed Pakistani intelligence network operating in Delhi-NCR.

The police said that the couple’s questioning had provided details about the manner in which Pakistan-based operatives coordinated with individuals in India through social media and encrypted communication platforms.

Dalit man forced to eat cattle dung in Maharashtra; 6 booked

Yohaana Varghese
MUMBAI

Six “cow vigilantes”, suspected to be Bajrang Dal members, have been booked for allegedly assaulting a Dalit man and forcing him to eat cattle dung after accusing him of attempting to sell a bull he had bought in Jalna district of Maharashtra. The man said the accused also threatened to humiliate his 11-year-old son, who was travelling with him.

While the incident took place in May, the victim lodged a complaint after a video of the purported assault went viral, officials said.

A case was registered at Jalna Taluka police station on Thursday under Sections 126(2) (wrongful restraint), 115(2) (voluntarily causing physical hurt to another person), and 189 (2) (unlawful assembly) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhi-

Incident happened in May but the victim lodged a complaint recently after a video showing it went viral

ta (BNS) besides provisions of the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act.

Parameshwar Suhas Hiwale, the complainant who works as a truck driver, told police that he was returning to Jalna with his 11-year-old son, and acquaintance Narayan Maroti Kamble, who had hired his services to purchase a bull at a weekly cattle market.

‘Casteist abuse’

A group claiming to be Bajrang Dal members and “cow protectors” allegedly followed them on motorbikes and waylaid the enclosed pick-up truck in Kanhaiyanagar area of Jalna. One of the accused caught

Govt. track record on free coaching plan is poor: Cong.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Citing the government’s poor record in implementing an existing free coaching scheme, the Congress on Friday questioned the Centre’s decision to provide free online coaching to students.

In a post on X, Congress communication chief Jairam Ramesh said Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi had, at the “Chhatron Ki Goonj” event in Kota on June 17, highlighted the growing dependence of Indian families on coaching centres and argued that an “extractive coaching industry” had supplanted the public education system.

Mr. Gandhi had pointed out that Indian families were spending 2.5 times more on coaching centres than the Union government invests in education, Mr. Ramesh said. He claimed that the disclosure had “forced” Prime Minister Narendra Modi to announce free online coaching for students in his Independence Day address, “in a desperate at-

tempt to escape growing public pressure”.

However, Mr. Ramesh questioned the government’s ability to deliver on the promise, citing the latest report of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Social Justice and Empowerment, tabled on August 10.

According to Mr. Ramesh, the Social Justice Ministry had set a target of enrolling 10,500 candidates under its existing scheme over three years, but had enrolled only 2,790 students – about 26% of the target.

He also said the allocation for the scheme had declined each year.

“Rather than fundamentally fix India’s broken education system or re-invest in public education, the Prime Minister has decided to instead invest public resources in online coaching,” Mr. Ramesh said. He termed the proposed initiative an “accountability-evading gimmick” and said the government’s record showed that it had “little capacity to implement this scheme successfully”.

Shutdown in Naga areas after four killed in Manipur

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

A day after alleged Kuki extremist groups ambushed and killed four Liangmai Naga civilians, Manipur’s Naga-inhabited areas observed a shutdown on Friday.

The United Naga Council (UNC), the apex body of Naga organisations in Manipur, called for a one-day *Genna* (a period of strict prohibition, rest, and community worship) across the Naga areas after the incident. A total shutdown was observed in Kamjong, Noney, Senapati, Tamenglong, and Ukhrul districts of Manipur.

Officials said the gunmen fired on at least six people on a village road between Makui Ashang and Thanamba Naga villages in the Kuki-dominated Kangpokpi district on Thursday, killing four of them.

The group was travelling from Makui village to

Senapati when they came under attack.

The fifth person, injured in the attack, was admitted to a hospital in Senapati, while a student leader, who was reported missing after the incident, managed to reach to safety.

“The mortal remains of the four victims reached Senapati for autopsy. Their last rites will be performed after a condolence service in their honour tomorrow (Saturday).” A.C. Thotso, the secretary of the UNC’s Working Committee, said.

Officials in Kangpokpi said the security forces could not retrieve the bodies on Thursday due to a blockade at a village on the way to the site of the ambush.

They retrieved the bodies on Friday morning and transported them to Senapati, where a large number of people turned up to pay their homage.

The UNC asked the State government to book the

perpetrators and deliver justice at the earliest. It also demanded a special investigation team (SIT) be formed to probe the case.

Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh called for sustained and collective efforts from all sections of society to overcome the prevailing trust deficit between different communities and restore lasting peace in Manipur.

“Today, there are people who do not want peace. We have to identify and book them as soon as possible,” Mr. Singh said.

Bomb explosion

A bomb exploded at the residence of Bharatiya Janata Party MLA and Manipur government spokesperson Sapam Ranjan Singh on Friday afternoon. No injuries were reported.

The Chief Minister visited the MLA’s residence and inspected the blast site. Both leaders condemned the incident.

Bail given to PFI member, HC cites lack of evidence

Chinmay Gaikwad
MUMBAI

The Bombay High Court has granted bail to Mohammed Iqbal Ibrahim Khan, an accused in a case registered under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA). The court ruled that witness statements against him did not establish the charges and that the trial would not conclude soon.

The court noted that the witness statements only indicated Khan’s membership in the Popular Front of India (PFI). However, they did not make out any of the offences charged against him. The Maharashtra Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS) arrested Khan in September 2022. He is currently in judicial custody. He was booked under various sections of the Indian Penal Code.

Fresh glacial lakes form at source of Nepal’s avalanche

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

Two more glacial lakes have formed in Nepal, near the apparent source of the ice-rock avalanche that triggered flooding in Nepal’s Bhoté Koshi-Trishuli river system on Wednesday.

While the formation of the lakes is known, information on the potential water outflow is unavailable, said Krishna Vatsa, Member and Head of the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA). “One is 19.80 hectares and the other is 7.28 hectares. We don’t have any estimates of the volume but there are moraines [piles of debris deposited by a moving glacier],” he told *The Hindu*. “These are lakes that have formed in Nepal and we don’t have direct knowledge of what’s happening there. We need to keep monitoring,” he added.

At least one of these lakes appears similar to the one independently confirmed by Suhora Technologies, a Noida-based space-data analytics firm, which also said it had identified a “newly formed water body” at the source of the ice-rock avalanche.

“Analysis of high-resolution optical satellite imagery acquired on August 27 shows a lake spanning approximately 20.25 hectares in the high-altitude Lhende Khola region, near the Nepal-Tibet border,” the company said in a

While the formation of lakes is known, details on potential water outflow is unavailable

statement on Friday.

Suhora said the lake’s formation is an important feature to monitor following the August 26 avalanche and subsequent flash flooding downstream. While a newly formed water body in the vicinity of an avalanche or debris-flow source could indicate water accumulation associated with the event, its presence by itself does not mean that another glacial-lake outburst flood is imminent.

The company said it would continue monitoring the lake’s extent and stability using satellite imagery. The assessment remains preliminary, and further observations and ground-based investigation will be needed to establish the lake’s origin, depth, stability, and potential downstream risk, it added.

‘No escape’

NDMA officials said that India had a monitoring network of both ground and satellite measurements that “were being improved”. However, there are still limitations. “We can give early warning 30 to 45 minutes in advance and that can save lives but when billions of litres of water gush, there is no escape,” an official said.

No contact still with 320 Indians; 400 stranded

21 pilgrims from Tamil Nadu return; 37 from Maharashtra stranded in Tibet on way to Kathmandu to take a flight home; India sends third aircraft with relief material and an expert panel on board

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

At least 320 Indians remain “uncontactable” and 400 others are stranded on the Chinese side following devastating flash floods along the Nepal-Tibet border, the External Affairs Ministry said on Friday, adding that India stands ready to extend all possible help to Kathmandu to deal with the situation.

External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar on Friday received 21 pilgrims from Tamil Nadu who were rescued from the disaster-hit areas of Nepal. Mr. Jaishankar said they were very thankful to the Nepalese Army for rescuing them.

“Right now, our effort is on supporting Nepal in the relief and rescue of people. Today, I spoke in the morning to the Nepal Foreign Minister Shisir Khanal. We have given them a range of support offers and they are evaluating it,” he said.

A third flight carrying 10 tonnes of humanitarian assistance has departed for Kathmandu.

The assistance includes portable generator sets, dignity kits, food packets and water purification tablets.

An 11-member team of doctors, paramedics and recce team for tunnel rescue operations is also on board, Mr. Jaishankar said in a post on X.



Safe return: External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar greets a group comprising 21 Tamil Nadu tourists, who were rescued from the floods-affected areas in Nepal. PTI

“In addition, we have also offered Bailey bridges along with their associated technical teams so that connectivity can be restored quickly in the affected parts of Nepal. One Bailey bridge is already in Nepal and can be deployed for relief efforts,” said Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal on Friday, announcing that the Government of India is arranging for the return of stranded Indians who were stranded in Nepal following the flash flood of August 26. He added that around 320 Indians remain “uncontactable”.

Mr. Jaiswal further said 400 Indians are stranded

on the Chinese side but they are safe. “They have been in touch with their family. Our embassy has been in touch with several of them.”

Mr. Jaiswal said that India has made a “specific offer” to Nepali authorities to dispatch NDRF teams along with their associated equipment that can help in the ongoing search and rescue operations. “We await a response from the Government of Nepal on this front. We stand ready to offer any other assistance that the Nepal authorities might require,” he said.

As many as 37 pilgrims from Maharashtra who were stranded in Tibet af-

ter completing their Kai-lash Mansarovar Yatra departed for Kathmandu on Friday morning following the intervention of Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis. According to the Maharashtra Chief Minister’s Office, the group, which includes pilgrims from Thane, Pune, Raigad, Alibag, and Dombivli, left Saga, Tibet, around 6 a.m. via the Nyalam check-post and is travelling safely towards the Nepalese capital. Their return flight from Kathmandu is scheduled for 2 p.m. on August 29, making it critical for them to reach the capital in time, the statement said.

(With inputs from PTI)

China says collapse of glacier in Nepal likely behind flood

Ananth Krishnan
BEIJING

A preliminary assessment suggested the collapse of a high-altitude glacier in Nepal was behind the mudslides and flash floods along the Nepal-China border, China’s Foreign Ministry said on Friday.

“We noted that experts and official institutions of China and Nepal have made preliminary assessments on the cause of the disaster,” Ministry spokesperson Lin Jian said. “According to their analysis, the disaster may have been triggered by the collapse of a high-altitude glacier in Nepal.”

Chinese authorities said 555 tourists had been evacuated from Gyirong county in Tibet. As of Friday, Chinese authorities had confirmed five deaths but added that over 558 people were still missing, including 260 foreign nationals.

Mr. Lin said China was in touch with the Indian Embassy and other embassies in Beijing and details of nationalities were being verified. “We have already notified the embassies of relevant countries and we will maintain communication with them,” he said.

Emergency meeting

Chinese President Xi Jinping on Friday chaired a rare emergency meeting of the Communist Party’s leadership “to deliberate and make arrangements on rescue and relief efforts”. A statement following the



Lin Jian

meeting, warned of complications involved in rescue efforts, and that operations were being carried out swiftly. China’s Premier and second-ranked leader Li Qiang arrived in Gyirong on Thursday to oversee rescue efforts and meet with those displaced.

“The disaster occurred in a severely cold plateau region with steep valleys, variable weather, many surrounding glaciers and glacial lakes, as well as potential geological hazards, which poses significant challenges to emergency rescue operations,” the statement said, adding that “every effort should be made to search for and rescue all missing Chinese and foreign nationals”. The statement said China will provide emergency aid to Nepal.

Mr. Xi sent a condolence message to Nepali President Ram Chandra Paudel, saying the two countries were “connected by mountains and rivers and share a common destiny”. “China is ready to actively assist Nepal in its rescue efforts and provide support and assistance to the best of its capability,” he said.

‘Won’t be surprised if CJP wins in one or two States’

T. Ramakrishnan
K. Muralitharan
CHENNAI

It would not be surprising if the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) captures power in one or two States, former Union Minister for Finance and Home Affairs P. Chidambaram said.

“But I do not know and cannot say whether it [the CJP] will be able to emerge as a third force at the all-India level,” Mr. Chidambaram told *The Hindu* 360, the Tamil YouTube channel of *The Hindu*, at his residence in Chennai on Wednesday.

Answering a question about whether the CJP would become a third force at the national level, the former Union Minister referred to the fledgling party’s campaign under the banner ‘School *Thik Karo*’, focusing on the con-

dition of government schools, and acknowledged the impact of the organisation’s drive on the powers that be. The campaign had made those in power “awake”. Announcements were being made about allocating funds to set government schools right. “Why should Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Ministers go to university campuses every day? [In the past,] when they visited colleges and universities for convocations, did they go around them?” he wondered. He added that “when a stone is thrown, it causes a ripple effect, doesn’t it?”

Giving the example of the Asom Gana Parishad (AGP), Mr. Chidambaram pointed out that it was the All Assam Students’ Union (AASU) that led to the birth of the AGP, which captured power in Assam for the



P. Chidambaram

first time in 1985. Besides, in Nepal, Balendra Shah, a leader of the Rastriya Swatantra Party, had become Prime Minister thanks to an agitation by Gen Z.

To another question on whether irregularities in public examinations were the only factor responsible for the recent youth agitation, the former Union Minister, who would turn 81 on September 16, referred to an editorial by *The Hin-*

du [‘Root causes: On India’s youth crisis’] and said: “I wholly accept it.” The irregularities were only “a consequence”. But unemployment and lack of income were the reasons. “When I was a student, people believed that graduates would receive a four-digit salary - ₹1,000 - which was a huge sum in those days. Those who took public examinations then would get government jobs. But today, even if you write the examinations, you do not get jobs,” Mr. Chidambaram observed. The unemployed included those who had finished engineering and medical courses and students of the Indian Institutes of Technology and Indian Institutes of Management.

On the paper leak in this year’s NEET-UG held by the National Testing Agen-

cy (NTA), he said that “it was waiting to happen”, considering the small number of permanent employees in the NTA and the fact that the test had to be held across the country.

Asked whether the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), which had been rendered virtually friendless after the 2026 Assembly election, would inch closer towards the BJP, Mr. Chidambaram answered that “there is no chance of that. If they [the DMK] did so, they would be causing a self-inflicted injury”. He also pointed out that on the issue of delimitation, the party had supported a resolution in the Assembly [urging the Centre to freeze the number of Lok Sabha seats at 543 and retain the current proportion of seats among the States], despite “conflicting voices” being heard earlier.

Reforms could have begun in 1981, but not during Rajaji’s time: former Union Minister

T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

India could have carried out economic reforms 10 years before 1991, but “certainly not” during the time of Swatantra Party’s founder C. Rajagopalachari, the first and only Indian Governor-General of Independent India, former Union Minister P. Chidambaram told *The Hindu* 360, the Tamil YouTube channel of *The Hindu*.

Asked whether the country would have been better off had it followed Rajagopalachari’s prescription of opening up the economy in the late 1950s through the early 1970s, Mr. Chidambaram, who

presented nine Union Budgets, acknowledged that the economic reforms could have begun in 1981. “At that time, [then Prime Minister] Indira Gandhi had made an attempt. But her Ministers and political leaders around her did not allow her to [get it done]... Even in 1985, it did not happen. If you go through the presidential address of the AICC [All India Congress Committee] chief and Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi at the Mumbai session of the Congress, he said all of what was talked about in 1991. He did not have a [conducive] political situation,” he said.

Elaborating further, he said that in the pre-1981 pe-

riod, capitalist countries claimed to be following an open market economy, but there was no rules-based order for the global economy. The World Trade Organisation did not exist then, he pointed out. “They [capitalist countries] had capital and technology. They called theirs an open economy. But the poor and middle-income countries could not have followed this...” he said.

Conceding there was a 10-year delay in initiating the reforms, Mr. Chidambaram, however, said that “in the days of Rajaji [who died in 1972], India did not have capital or technology to follow the open economy” system.

Resist pressure to join BJP, Mamata tells party loyalists

The Hindu Bureau
KOLKATA

Trinamool Congress chairperson Mamata Banerjee on Friday asked her loyalists not to succumb to political pressure and join the BJP. While speaking at the foundation day of her party’s student wing, the Trinamool Congress Chhatra Parishad (TMCP), Ms. Banerjee assured them their party would soon return to power and write a new political history.

“I tell my colleagues to remain strong and fearless. If necessary, spend a month eating jail food, but do not surrender politically,” Ms. Banerjee said.

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Prospective service providers having the requisite experience may submit the documents as per PQC clauses and queries through email addressed to email IDs mentioned in PQC document.
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Tenders Available at: <https://srmetender.mahatransco.in>;
Due date for online submission upto: 07.09.2026, 11:00 Hrs;
Tender Opening 07.09.2026, 12:00 Hrs if possible
Sd/- Chief Engineer
EHV PC O&M Zone Nagpur

कार्यालय, अधीनस्थ अधिकारी वरून परीक्षेच्या प्रत्येक, कार्यालय सेल काम करत सेक्टर गिरगा-कोटपुली-बेहरो					
E-mail: sewdsce.kot.behrro@rajasthan.gov.in					
Sr. No. 401-05					
Date: 20-8-2026					
NOTICE INVITING BID NIT NO- 22 YEAR 2026-27					
Bids for Watershed Development Works are invited from interested bidders up to 30.08.2026 at 6:00 PM as per following details. Other particulars of bid may be visited on the procurement portal https://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in of the state departmental website.					
Sr. No	Block	NIB No	Estimate (Rs in Lacs)	NIB CODE	UBN CODE
1	Kotputli Mjsa 2.2		57.84		WSC2627WSOB01917
2	Viratnagar Mjsa 2.2		143.45		WSC2627WSOB01918
3	Neemrana Mjsa 2.2		153.43		WSC2627WSOB01919
4	Bansur Mjsa 2.3		58.31		WSC2627WSOB01920
5	Bansur Mjsa 2.2	22/2026-27	102.11	WS-C2627A1052	WSC2627WSOB01921
6	Paota Mjsa 2.2		114.35		WSC2627WSOB01922
7	Viratnagar Mjsa 2.3		75.82		WSC2627WSOB01923
8	Neemrana Mjsa 2.3		58.96		WSC2627WSOB01924
9	Viratnagar pmksy 2.0		2.05		WSC2627WSOB01925
(RAJESH KUMAR GUPTA) Superintending Engineer WCDC Kotputli-behro					
DIPR/C/15409/2026					

**Uttarakhand Urban Sector Development Agency (UUSDA)**
Urban Development Department, Government of Uttarakhand
777, Saatvik Tower, Kaulagarh Road, Rajendra Nagar, Dehradun
Telephone +91-135-2753894, Tele-fax +91- 135-2754895
Email: uusdiip@gmail.com, Website: www.uusda.uk.gov.in

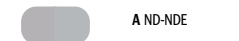
NOTICE INVITING TENDER (NIT)
Urban Development Department (UDD), Government of Uttarakhand (GoU) has received financing from Kreditanstalt für Wiederaufbau Bank (KfW) for the **Rishikesh Integrated Urban Infrastructure Development Programme**. The project aims to develop and strengthen urban infrastructure in Uttarakhand through the implementation of essential urban infrastructure components and intends to apply part of the proceeds of the Loan for the works as mentioned in the table below.
The “**Program Director**”, Uttarakhand Urban Sector Development Agency (UUSDA), Government of Uttarakhand” (the **Employer**) invites online bids through the Uttarakhand state e-procurement portal <https://uktenders.gov.in>, from eligible Bidders for the execution of the work as detailed below:

S. No	Name of Work	Package No.	Invitation of Bid No.	Last Date & Time of Bid Submission
1.	Development of Water Supply System with 01 year O&M, at Rishikesh, in Uttarakhand.	WS-RK-01	514373	14th October 2026 till 04:00 PM, (16:00 Hrs.)

Publishing Date of Bid document29.08.2026 at 09:00 AM, (09:00 Hrs.)
Date of Pre-Bid Meeting14.09.2026 at 12:00 Noon, (12:00 Hrs.)
Bid Submission Start Date21.09.2026 at 03:00 PM, (15:00 Hrs.)
Last date for submission of original EMD in the office of Bid inviting officer12.10.2026 at 04:00 PM, (16:00 Hrs.)
Bid Submission Closing & Last Date/Time for downloading of the Bid document14.10.2026 at 04:00 PM, (16:00 Hrs.)
Bid Opening Date and time14.10.2026 at 05:00 PM, (17:00 Hrs.)

The prospective bidders can download the detailed bid document in the prescribed format and upload the bid on the website, <https://uktenders.gov.in>. Program Director, UUSDA reserves the right to reject any or all the proposals or to cancel the entire process without assigning any reason thereof. Further details of the bid document including subsequent addendum/corrigendum/cancellation etc. may be downloaded from the website <https://uktenders.gov.in>.

Program Director
UUSDA



A ND-NDE

INBRIEF



Bangladeshi national to plead guilty in actor stabbing case

Mohammad Shariful Islam, the accused in the stabbing of actor Saif Ali Khan, has approached a Mumbai court with an application to plead guilty. Islam, a Bangladeshi national, is in judicial custody. His lawyer informed the court of his client's willingness to plead guilty and request leniency. The court has directed the prosecution to file its response and has adjourned the hearing to September 11. The accused faces charges under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita for robbery with a deadly weapon, causing grievous hurt, and house trespass. He also faces charges under the Foreigners Act and Passport (Entry into India) Rules. The incident occurred on January 16, 2025, at the actor's apartment in Bandra.

CNG prices hiked by ₹3.89 a kg as LNG prices remain elevated

North India's largest city-gas distributor Indraprastha Gas Ltd. (IGL) said late on Friday that it has increased the price of compressed natural gas (CNG) across all its retail stations by ₹3.89 per kg as international prices of the input gas, that is, LNG, continues to remain elevated amid the re-escalation of the conflict in West Asia. With the latest revision, the vehicular gas in Delhi would now cost ₹86.98 for every kg. Friday's hike would be the fifth such increase since the onset of the conflict in West Asia. IGL said that global LNG prices have nearly doubled as compared to pre-crisis period. Prior to this, the price of CNG in several cities of North India has increased cumulatively by ₹6 per kg across four tranches since May 15.

57 lakh active workers await e-KYC under new job scheme

Centre had earlier assured that 'existing e-KYC verified job cards will remain valid until issuance of the new Gramin Rozgar Guarantee Cards'; States repeatedly missed e-KYC verification deadlines

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

The e-KYC verification rate of registered workers stood at 71%, two months after the launch of the new rural employment scheme, Viksit Bharat Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) [VB-G RAM G]. The government earlier said that workers who were e-KYC verified under the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme (MGNREGS) are eligible to avail of work under the new scheme.

On the eve of the nationwide rollout of VB-G RAM G, Union Rural Development Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan assured that "existing e-KYC verified job cards will remain valid until the issuance of the new Gramin Rozgar Guarantee Cards, ensuring uninterrupted access to employment and timely payment of wages".

Meanwhile, the e-KYC verification rate of active workers – those who availed of work at least once in the last three years – is much higher at 94.88%. However, this still leaves 57 lakh workers unverified.



The delay raises questions about whether people could face difficulty accessing work because of administrative gaps. FILE PHOTO

The Ministry has allowed exceptions in a few cases where job cards have not been e-KYC verified and has reiterated that no eligible worker will be left behind, while simultaneously making e-KYC verification a condition for availing of work under VB-G RAM G.

The number of active workers left behind is also significant when viewed against comparative employment generation under MGNREGS and VB-G RAM G in July. Official data (as of August 9, 2026) show that only 7.67 crore person-days were generated under the VB-G RAM G scheme in July 2026, which was 49.94% lower than the 15.33 crore person-days

generated under MGNREGS in the same month last year. A person-day is a unit of measurement based on the amount of work done by one person in a working day.

Missed deadlines

At a meeting on January 30, the Rural Development Ministry asked States to complete e-KYC verification of all remaining active workers within a week as part of the transition to the new VB-G RAM G system, the RTI application filed by Chakradhar Buddha of the National Campaign for People's Right to Information (NCPRI) revealed.

On February 12, States were again asked to complete e-KYC verification of

active workers, this time by the end of February. Nearly seven months later, the latest figures show that the target was not met.

Implementation gaps

With e-KYC still pending for a section of active workers, and for a much larger section of all registered workers, the delay raises questions about whether workers could face difficulties accessing work because of the gap between the Ministry's deadlines and the pace of implementation on the ground.

Among the four States with the largest MGNREGS workforces, Tamil Nadu has the highest e-KYC rate in both categories, with 99.32% among active workers and 84.89% among all registered workers. Rajasthan follows at 95.66% and 69.45%, Uttar Pradesh at 94.21% and 58.89%, and Andhra Pradesh at 90.4% and 82.32%.

West Bengal reported e-KYC rates of 97.3% among active workers and 85.49% among all registered workers. Bihar reported 89.19% among active workers and 58.05% among all registered workers, among the lowest rates for the latter category among large States.

Nilekani-led panel on exam reforms seeks suggestions

Maitri Porecha
NEW DELHI

A high-powered task force constituted by the Centre to recommend reforms to public examinations, including those conducted by the National Testing Agency, has invited suggestions from stakeholders, such as students, parents, teachers, and academic institutions, as part of a public consultation exercise.

Examination-conducting and test-indenting bodies, subject matter experts, technology professionals, industry bodies, and civil society organisations can also submit their suggestions.

"As part of this exercise, the task force considers it extremely useful to benefit from the experience, knowledge and perspectives of all stakeholders," the Ministry of Personnel, Public Grievances and Pensions said in a statement.

The task force, led by Infosys co-founder Nandan Nilekani, was constituted following the leak of the NEET-UG, 2026 question paper. Suggestions may relate to conduct and security of public examinations, examination design and assessment methodology, governance, accountability and institutional arrangements, prevention, detection and redress of exami-

Students, parents, teachers, and academic institutions can write in

nation malpractices. It has also invited suggestions on use of technology, including secure computer-based testing as well as creation and augmentation of examination infrastructure.

Suggestions have also been invited on inclusive examination framework for better access across social, economic, regional, and linguistic groups.

The task force has also sought suggestions on how to institute transparency, grievance redress, and stakeholder communication as well as measures to promote student well-being throughout the examination process and any other measure that may add value in the examination system. Submissions may be made in English, Hindi or regional languages by September 13.

Suggestions can be submitted through the website <https://examreforms-taskforce.dopt.gov.in>, by calling the number 1800-180-4747, by sending a WhatsApp message with the text "hptf" to +917827042830, or by emailing ExamReformsTaskforce@dopt.gov.in.

OBC creamy layer income test issue stuck between Ministries, says House panel chief

Abhinav Lakshman
NEW DELHI

The issue concerning the two components of OBC creamy layer exclusion – income/wealth test and equivalence of posts – appears to be stuck between the Ministry of Personnel, Public Grievances and Pensions and the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment, said BJP MP and chief of the House panel on welfare of OBCs, Ganesh Singh.

He said ideally the Social Justice Ministry should formulate the policy based on the Supreme Court's reading of the income test in March and then bring it to the Cabinet. "That has not happened yet," Mr. Singh said.

The judgment had ruled that the Department of

Personnel and Training (DoPT) was practising "hostile discrimination" in applying the income test differently to OBC candidates with parents in government service and OBC candidates with parents in jobs where the equivalence with government posts had not been established.

It noted that for the latter category, income from salaries was being included and directed the government to exclude salaries from the test, and create supernumerary posts for OBC candidates who were denied non-creamy layer status based on such an application of the test.

While the government had six months to implement the directions, the issue caused a furore among sections of OBCs after the government approached



Ganesh Singh. SANSAD TV

the Supreme Court with applications saying it was "extremely difficult" to implement the court's reading of the income test retrospectively.

The government also argued that there must be cases where income from salaries must be included in applying the income test.

Under Mr. Singh's leadership, the committee has consistently pointed out that the government

was incorrectly applying the income test to OBC candidates of parents in jobs without equivalence with government posts, principally by interpreting a 2004 DoPT letter.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, Mr. Singh said, "The Personnel Ministry and the Social Justice Ministry seem to be passing the job along to each other. Ideally, the Social Justice Ministry should have formed the policy on equivalence of posts and application of the income test so that it can be placed before the Cabinet. But that has not happened."

The Cabinet Minister in charge of the Personnel Ministry is Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the Social Justice Ministry is headed by Virendra Singh. The committee, under Mr.

Singh, has also been pushing for the Social Justice Ministry to establish equivalence between posts.

The last time the House panel on OBC welfare was seized of the matter was in hearings related to the DoPT's implementation of the reservation policy for OBCs. In these hearings in 2025, the Ministry of Personnel had said that the issue was related to OBC candidates with parents in jobs where equivalence had not been established, and that it was the Social Justice Ministry that was responsible for establishing this equivalence, and responding to the House Committee.

However, officials told *The Hindu* that the Social Justice Ministry has yet to respond to the committee on this issue.

Press Trust of India
JAIPUR

A case file related to an accused repeat offender in a financial fraud case has gone missing from the Rajasthan High Court Registry, with the Supreme Court allowing the petitioner to seek an early hearing of the matter.

The case comes at a time when the functioning of the Rajasthan High Court is under scrutiny following allegations made by a Supreme Court Justice and advocates' associations. However, the missing records in the case, by themselves, do not establish any connection with those allegations.

The Supreme Court, while hearing the case on August 10, did not interfere with the proceedings be-

fore the Rajasthan High Court and dismissed the special leave petition (SLP).

However, it allowed the petitioner to request an early hearing of the pending case before the High Court, according to the order.

The apex court, in its order, also said that if the records were not traceable in the High Court registry, the petitioner could approach the registrar general to have the records searched and placed before the High Court.

The case concerns Gyan Chand Agarwal and two other accused, who approached the High Court seeking quashing of a case against them. According to the petition filed before the Supreme Court, the records of the quashing petitions were found missing

from the Criminal Branch of the Rajasthan High Court Registry on April 10.

FIR filed by SOG

Following this, the HC directed the registrar (judicial) to submit a detailed report on the missing records. The apex court plea said the report submitted by the registry was not satisfactory when the matter was considered on April 22. The case relates to an FIR registered by the Special Operations Group (SOG) in 2023. The accused face allegations including cheating, criminal breach of trust, forgery and criminal conspiracy.

The petitioner alleged that Mr. Agarwal did not join the investigation despite an earlier direction of the High Court.

SUDOKU

			7		3			1
	9							8
	6	2	9		8			
	8	3					7	9
4								5
9	7					1	2	
			3		2	5	9	
8							1	
2			5		9			

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

Solution to previous puzzle

S	C	H	O	P	T	E	A	C	H	E	R
A	N	N	A	P	T	I	S	M	A	L	
H	U	R	S	T	I	N	G				
I	T	H	E	R	A	P	O	N	E		
G	O	O	S	E	F	L	E	S	H	'S	N
H	O	T			S	A	T				
W	I	N	K	I	N	G					
T	O	A	M	E	A	L					
T	O	A	M	E	A	L					
U	N	A	S								
N	A	S									
T	I	R	A	N							
U	N	F	O	R	G	E	T	A	B	L	E

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

6	8	3	5	7	1	9	4	2
5	2	4	9	8	6	1	3	7
9	7	1	2	4	3	6	8	5
7	6	8	4	5	2	3	1	9
2	1	9	7	3	8	5	6	4
4	3	5	6	1	9	7	2	8
8	9	6	1	2	7	4	5	3
3	4	7	8	6	5	2	9	1
1	5	2	3	9	4	8	7	6

FAITH

Sacred hierarchy

The sacred or spiritual hierarchy and roles are an interconnected relationship between the Bhagavan (God), the Acharya (Guru), and the Bhagavatas (devotees). Without Bhagavan, one cannot reach an Acharya, and without an Acharya, one cannot attain Bhagavan, said Sri Velukkudi Krishnan Swamy in a discourse. Bhagavan (*uddharagan*) provides for us; the Acharya (*upakarakar*) guides us, and the Bhagavatas (*uddhesyargal*) serve as revered guides. Devotees act as an essential bridge between God and the seeker; for instance, when Vibhishana sought refuge in Lord Rama, he approached Him through Sugriva (a devotee), knowing that Bhagavan accepts a seeker through His devotees. Consequently, Rama convinced Sugriva, asked him to bring Vibhishana, and granted him refuge.

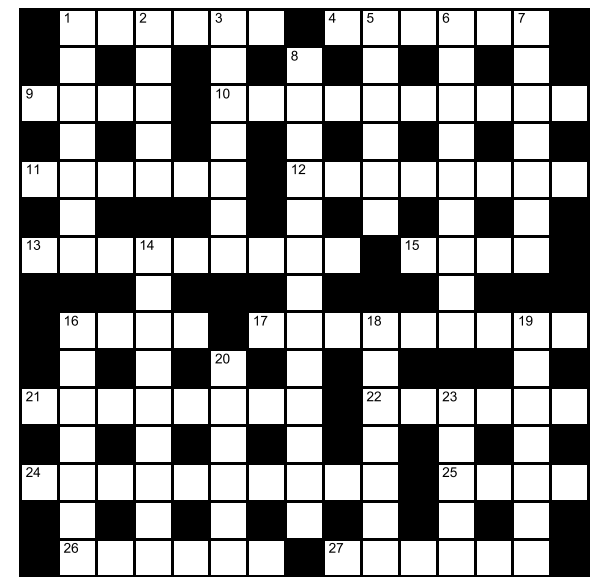
This spiritual path operates through a continuous chain of guidance, in which no true Guru demands surrender to himself. Instead, he directs the disciple upward to Bhagavan – Bhagavatas point to the Acharya, and the Acharya points to Bhagavan. The journey of devotion (Bhakti) begins when the Acharya sows the seed of devotion in the seeker's heart, which the Bhagavatas (devotees) then nurture through spiritual conversations. Once this plant blossoms and bears the fruit of devotion, Bhagavan is the ultimate enjoyer (Bhokta) of that devotion. Nammazhwar's verse from the 10th decad in Tiruvaimozhi narrates that he prays to Lord Narayana, saying, "You have nurtured a portion of devotion in me and enjoyed it. Do not leave me half-consumed here in this material world. Grow this devotion into full maturity; take me to the supreme abode, and consume me entirely as your ultimate offering."

THE CROSSWORD+ 14885

(set by Hypatia)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

SCAN TO PLAY



- Across**
- Anguished cry about president joining American country (6)
 - Complied with rule in charge of measurement system (6)
 - Teacher giving us recognition, chiefly at University (4)
 - Sympathetic hospital section working with debt obligations (10)
 - Novel has article about fine emperor (6)

- Play game with turn in row (8)
 - Hypatia had set clue earlier and had to explain (9)
 - Approve lying about animal close to zoo (4)
 - Prize art regularly gathering support (4)
 - Spooner's gambler secures mail collector (6,3)
 - Advocate flipping cronies in friendly gesture (8)
 - Port city (6)
 - A wine almost subduing angry, sick and prickly animals (10)
 - Can't steal? (4)
 - He believes that he is truthful to some extent (6)
 - Caught monkeys earning rupees in stunts (6)
- Down**
- Crazy old uncle nicking second brief (7)
 - Philosopher taking tips from practices learnt usually through observations (5)
 - Ignored in dark ages, Hindus revolted every now and then (7)
 - Hug one in trouble? It's all you need (6)
 - Managed to take one month to recruit oddly keen miracle worker(9)
 - Relish slice filled by husband with rising desire (7)
 - Get help. Let's stop the curse! (5,3,5)
 - What one can do in dating sites to outwit someone? (9)
 - Pick up hint about artist and kings in language (7)
 - Yet am ashamedly concealing fuss (7)
 - Speakers occasionally sort out patriot from the South (7)
 - Cash limit unfortunately hit these entitlements (6)
 - Loves nuts to crack (5)

CM

ISLAMABAD
Iftikhar Gillani, of ruling PML-N, elected as PoK ‘Prime Minister’



Barrister Iftikhar Ali Gillani was on Friday elected to the post of ‘Prime Minister’ of Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) following recent elections marred by violent protests and allegations of massive rigging. Mr. Gillani, of the ruling Pakistan Muslim League Nawaz, secured 30 of the 44 votes in the legislative assembly. PTI

KYIV
Russian drones batter Ukraine’s Kyiv region for the second day



Russian forces on Friday resumed their drone barrage of Ukraine’s Kyiv region, firing 164 drones, and hit more than a dozen apartment buildings and storage depots in a second straight day of aerial attacks, officials said. The attacks killed one person and wounded two others, according to officials. AP

JENIN
Israel says it killed ‘three Hamas militants’ in West Bank air strike



The Israeli military said it struck and killed three “Hamas militants” on Friday in occupied West Bank, a rare air strike in the Palestinian territory that has seen growing tension. However, the armed wing of Palestinian Islamic Jihad said in a statement that the three killed were its fighters. In a statement, Hamas denounced the strike. AFP

OSLO
Norway’s King Harald V dies at 89; his son becomes King Haakon VIII



Norway’s King Harald died on Friday aged 89, the palace said, and amidst widespread mourning and tributes his 53-year-old son Haakon immediately succeeded him on the throne. Haakon, who announced he would reign under the name King Haakon VIII, takes over a monarchy long hailed for its modernity and modesty. AFP

Dhaka ‘positively’ weighs joining Mecca Pact

BNP-led government says the interests of the country and its people would be given the highest priority in joining any defence agreement or alliance; Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman says Bangladesh’s accession is not currently under discussion and that it has not received any formal proposal yet; major Opposition parties voice support

Rabiul Alam
DHAKA

Bangladesh will give positive consideration to joining the Mecca Pact, the trilateral defence agreement signed by Saudi Arabia, Turkiye and Pakistan, should its members propose bringing Dhaka into the framework, Bangladesh Foreign Minister Dr. Khalilur Rahman told Parliament on Thursday. The BNP-led government’s such consideration has also drawn support from the country’s main Opposition parties, including Bangladesh Jamaat-e-Islami and the National Citizen Party (NCP).

Responding to a supplementary question from Independent Member of Parliament Rumin Farhana

during the third session of the 13th Parliament, Mr. Rahman said Bangladesh’s accession to the pact was not currently under discussion and would depend on the intentions of the agreement’s existing signatories. “If they express interest in bringing Bangladesh into this pact, the government will certainly consider it positively,” he said.

Ms. Farhana had asked what benefits Bangladesh stood to gain from joining the pact, signed on August 7, and whether Dhaka intended to do so.

Mr. Rahman said the government viewed the agreement, struck between the three countries, as a positive development, but that the question of Bangladesh’s membership had “not yet arisen,” since



Khalilur Rahman says Dhaka’s accession to the pact would depend on the intentions of the agreement’s existing signatories. AFP

no formal proposal had been extended.

“The time has not yet come to weigh the pros and cons of the pact before a proposal for Bangladesh’s inclusion is made,” he said, adding that the government would take all aspects into account if and when such a proposal materialised.

“We will certainly keep all these matters under consideration,” the Minister said.

Mr. Rahman also suggested the pact could, if expanded further, evolve into a collective self-defence

mechanism for the wider Muslim world.

“This is our family. This is an internal matter of the Muslim family. Others need not be concerned about it.”

Replying to another supplementary question from Bangladesh Jamaat-e-Islami lawmaker Mir Ahmad Bin Quasem, the Foreign Minister also said Bangladesh would use its presidency of the United Nations General Assembly to serve all 193 member states rather than pursue the interests of any particular country.

Swift endorsement

The government’s such move draws swift endorsement from the key Opposition parties. Dr. Shafiqur Rahman, Leader of the Op-

position in Parliament and Ameer of Bangladesh Jamaat-e-Islami, said on Thursday that any decision to join the Mecca Pact is entirely Bangladesh’s own affair.

“If Bangladesh makes a decision in the interests and for the needs of the country and its people, there is no reason for anyone else to feel suffocated by it,” he added.

The National Citizen Party (NCP) went further, welcoming the possibility of Bangladesh’s entry outright. In a press release on Wednesday, the party said the pact could open avenues for political and military coordination and cooperation in defence technology, strengthening Bangladesh’s security, trade and strategic ties

with key countries in the Muslim world.

The party cautioned, however, that any decision to join a collective defence framework should rest on a comprehensive assessment of the country’s long-term national interests, security and strategic capabilities, rather than on political considerations or immediate diplomatic calculations.

The Mecca Joint Defence Agreement was signed in the Saudi city by Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan and Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, establishing a mutual-defence clause under which an attack on any one signatory would be treated as an attack on all three.

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN

Iran left the door open to diplomacy on Friday, six months into a war with the United States that has upended the West Asia, but only if Washington abandons its pressure campaign.

“Putting diplomacy back on track isn’t impossible. It hinges on U.S. understanding of one simple fact: pressure doesn’t work,” Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi posted on X on Friday.

In the latest effort to reinvigorate diplomacy, Mr. Araghchi met his Qatari counterpart on Thursday in Tehran to discuss the Strait of Hormuz, closed by the Islamic republic at the start of the war.

Syria’s Sharaa names Kurdish leader Abdi as presidential adviser

Agence France-Presse
DAMASCUS

Syrian President Ahmed al-Sharaa appointed Kurdish leader Mazloum Abdi as a presidential adviser, state media said on Friday, days after Mr. Abdi announced the dissolution of his Kurdish forces under an integration deal with Damascus.

The Education Ministry also published a decision authorising Kurdish-language instruction in public and private schools.

“Mustafa Khalil Abdi is appointed as adviser to the presidency of the republic,” announced the decree, signed by Mr. Sharaa and published by state



Mazloum Abdi

news agency SANA.

Mr. Abdi, who has been known by several different names, was for years the leader of the Kurdish-led Syrian Democratic Forces (SDF), the Washington-backed group at the forefront of the battle against the Islamic State jihadist group.

China removes two high-ranking officers from military body

Agence France-Presse
BEIJING

China removed two high-ranking officers from the country’s main military body on Friday, state media reported, seven months after it was announced that Zhang Youxia and Liu Zhenli were being investigated for “serious violations of the law”.

Mr. Zhang’s position as the more senior of two vice chairmen on the Central Military Commission (CMC) had made him China’s highest-ranked general.

In January though, the Defence Ministry said that Mr. Zhang and Mr. Liu were “suspected of serious

violations of discipline and the law”, a common euphemism for corruption.

The announcement fit into the sweeping anti-graft drive that has defined President Xi Jinping’s time in power.

On Friday, state news agency Xinhua said in a report on a meeting of the standing committee of China’s Parliament that “the meeting decided to remove Zhang Youxia from the post of Vice Chairman of the Central Military Commission of the People’s Republic of China”.

Mr. Liu, who was chief of staff of the CMC’s joint staff department, which oversees combat planning, was also removed, it said.

Civil rights rally targets voting changes pushed by Trump ahead of Nov. polls

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

Civil rights activists gathered in Washington on Friday in a major show of opposition to restrictions on voting being pushed by President Donald Trump and Republican redistricting ahead of November’s U.S. midterm elections.

The “Defend the Vote” march brought protesters to the National Mall 63 years to the day after Martin Luther King Jr. delivered his “I Have a Dream” speech during the landmark 1963 March on Washington.

Organised by veteran civil rights leader Al Sharpton and led by King’s son Martin Luther King III, the



People attend the ‘Defend the Vote’ rally and march for voting rights, at the Lincoln Memorial in Washington on Friday. REUTERS

demonstration was expected to draw support from more than 90 civil rights, labour, faith and community organisations.

Prominent speakers include left-wing Senator Bernie Sanders and Democratic congresswoman

Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez.

“Defending the vote means defending the foundation of our democracy. Sixty three years after my father stood at the Lincoln Memorial, we are called to march again, not only in remembrance, but in ac-

tion,” Mr. King III said ahead of the event.

Organisers say voting rights are under their most serious threat in decades following a Supreme Court ruling in April that weakened protections under the landmark 1965 Voting Rights Act.

The decision cleared the way for Republican-led states in the South to redraw congressional districts in ways civil rights groups say dilute the political influence of Black voters.

Civil rights organisations have challenged Mr. Trump’s executive order, while courts have issued a rapid series of conflicting decisions over how much of it can take effect.

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Weekend Sport



GETTY IMAGES

Why is Alexandra Eala, the 21-year-old from the Philippines, drawing huge crowds around the world? And how could this play out at the year's final Major in the USA, which has a history of rewarding marketable athletes and turning them into brands unto themselves?

N. Sudarshan

There are two places in the world where you would want to do well as a tennis player. The first is Wimbledon, because of its history, prestige and the sheer romance of playing in pristine white on lush green grass, the sport's original combination. Then comes the United States of America, with all its glitz, glamour and the seemingly unlimited marketing potential that can turn sportspersons into walking billboards and brands unto themselves. Being a nation of immigrants, it is a melting pot of multiple ethnicities and home to many diasporas, which means every achievement has a de facto worldwide audience.

Capturing the imagination

Over the last two months, Alexandra Eala has aced this twin-test and captured the transatlantic imagination, and of the world at large. At Wimbledon, she put together her best Grand Slam streak by reaching the fourth round, the first from the Philippines to do so. En route, she dethroned six-time Major winner Iga Swiatek in straight sets. Weeks later in Washington, she came up with another stirring run to clinch the Mubadala DC

“We have a really strong sense of community, and we uplift each other. When positive things happen to other Filipinos around the world, we share the happiness”
ALEXANDRA EALA

Open WTA 500, her first-ever Tour title. Eala beat Slam finalists Qinwen Zheng and Leylah Fernandez, No. 10 Elina Svitolina, four-time Major champion Naomi Osaka and No. 3 Jessica Pegula. The come-from-behind victory over Pegula – the 2024 US Open runner-up – came in a rain-affected final played across two days, and saw an astonishing 6-0 scoreline in the decider. The performance helped the 21-year-old break into the world's top-20 – she is No. 18 now – and sent her fame skyrocketing. So much so that sportswear behemoth Nike designed a signature black t-shirt, replete with Sampaguita flower motifs and Tagalog phrases – the Philippines' national flower and native tongue – and it sold out instantly! Ahead of the season's fourth and final Slam starting this Sunday (August 30) in the United States, 'Eala Mania' is tennis' foremost buzz phrase. “It's so refreshing and nice to see how they've embraced her, and how well she has handled the stardom that has come with her being from the Philippines,” Pegula said after the Washington final. “It's crazy how she deals with it every single week, which just shows her maturity as a player and a person. It's cool to see what she's brought to the women's game.” Sports fandom, at times, can seem irrational,

emotionally charged and borderline delusional, but the investment in Eala appears to follow a certain logic. For one, she is a top-notch tennis player, seen not just in her recent form but also from last year when she made the semifinal in Miami while ranked 140. She beat 2017 French Open champion Jelena Ostapenko, 2025 Australian Open winner Madison Keys, and Swiatek consecutively. In fact, the contests versus Keys and Swiatek were her first against top-10 players. Since then, she has accumulated seven more top-10 wins, including five in her last six outings. According to the Australian Open website, since 1990, only three other players have had more wins in their first 13 matches against top-10 opposition – Martina Navratilova, Monica Seles and Steffi Graf. The lefty angle Secondly, Eala is a lefty, a species instantly placed in a different aesthetic category. And the tennis universe appears desperate for the next left-handed Major champion, for there is none active now among men or women, with the last being Marketa Vondrousova at Wimbledon in 2023. There is her connection with 22-time Slam titlist Rafael Nadal, whose academy she trained at starting 2018 before graduating in 2023.



It's refreshing to see how well she has handled the stardom that has come with her being from the Philippines. It's cool to see what she's brought to the women's game
JESSICA PEGULA

“She is fearless and takes the ball early,” former World No. 4 Greg Rusedski – a fellow southpaw – said on his podcast. “Her mentality is so good and strong. The one area she needs to win a Major is to get that serve a bit better and more powerful. If she can get that, she's definitely in the mix because the rest of her game is there.” Thirdly, she is from Asia, an outlier in tennis success stories when compared to Europe and America. From Li Na to Kei Nishikori to Naomi Osaka, all have had fervent fan followings because Asia has been thirsty for torchbearers. It helps that the continent is expected to be the next driver of the world economy and among the biggest markets, thereby increasing a sportsperson's commercial value in the region. Also, in a developing nation like the Philippines, which isn't historically known for wide-ranging sporting excellence, an athlete's journey often intertwines with that of the nation and their goals become synonymous. It is clear in the case of Eala and tennis, for the Southeast Asian archipelago is more famous for boxing and basketball. Manny Pacquiao, one of the greatest professional boxers of all-time, is Eala's compatriot, and after the latter's triumph in Washington, he wrote on social media: “Down in the first round [set] but got back up. That is the heart of the Filipino! Congrats Alex Eala, our new champion!” Recently, in Taguig City back home, Eala was honoured with a giant mural on a basketball court that once celebrated icons such as LeBron James and Kobe Bryant.

Strong sense of community “I think we're just very proud of where we come from,” Eala said at Wimbledon. “We have a really strong sense of community, and we uplift each other. When positive things happen to other Filipinos around the world, we share the enjoyment and the happiness.” This group identity and cohesion was well reflected in Toronto where Eala played her first match after the title at Washington. *The Athletic* reported that Tennis Canada's head of ticketing Jason Maglantay, himself a Filipino, was inundated with queries from the diaspora about where Eala would play her opening tie.

She was eventually put on centre court on a Wednesday night, and tickets sold out in 30 minutes, according to Maglantay. “A sold-out Wednesday night this early in the tournament is really unheard of,” said Karl Hale, the Canadian Open tournament director. There is every chance that this pattern will repeat at the US Open. Grand Slams neither require publicity nor need to go the extra mile to sell tickets, but Alexandra Eala in a night session at the Arthur Ashe Stadium is a match made in heaven. The United States Tennis Association lives for such moments, and has a history of awarding the world's most marketable athletes with show-court appearances. The high-profile example one can think of is the return of Maria Sharapova from her doping ban in 2017 as a wild card, on Arthur Ashe under the exotic New York night sky, sporting a sparkling black dress and a glittering jacket. Eala's career graph is nowhere close to the Russian's, for Sharapova was a five-time Major winner. But fans and businesses connect with both performance and potential. Nike, it is reported, has already designed a basketball-themed bespoke outfit for Eala. A deep run in the United States may or may not materialise, but 'Eala Mania' is here to stay!

STACKING UP



ATP Men's Top 15

#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Jannik Sinner	25	12,800	17
2	Alexander Zverev	29	7,790	20
3	Carlos Alcaraz	23	7,160	17
4	Felix Auger-Aliassime	26	4,640	22
5	Novak Djokovic	39	3,770	16
6	Flavio Cobolli	24	3,720	26
7	Alex de Minaur	27	3,650	24
8	Daniil Medvedev	30	3,580	23
9	Ben Shelton	23	3,480	22
10	Taylor Fritz	28	3,475	22
11	Arthur Fils	22	3,140	18
12	Frances Tiafoe	28	2,680	22
13	Rafael Jodar	19	2,671	22
14	Lorenzo Musetti	24	2,605	22
15	Learner Tien	20	2,565	22



Sumit Nagal
Rank 234 ▲ 5 spots



Manas Dhamne
Rank 372 ▼ 4 spots

WTA Women's Top 15

#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Aryna Sabalenka	28	8,575	18
2	Elena Rybakina	27	8,141	21
3	Jessica Pegula	32	7,265	19
4	Coco Gauff	22	6,704	18
5	Mirra Andreeva	19	5,443	20
6	Linda Noskova	21	5,028	20
7	Karolina Muchova	30	4,883	20
8	Iga Swiatek	25	4,809	19
9	Elina Svitolina	31	4,689	17
10	Amanda Anisimova	24	4,533	15
11	Marta Kostyuk	24	3,980	16
12	Belinda Bencic	29	2,995	18
13	Naomi Osaka	28	2,846	18
14	Iva Jovic	18	2,671	23
15	Victoria Mboko	19	2,531	19



Sahaja Yamalapalli
Rank 342 ▲ 2 spots



Vaishnavi Adkar
Rank 389 ▲ 1 spot



F1 Drivers' standings

#	Driver	Team	Points	Wins
1	A.K. Antonelli	Mercedes	242	6
2	G. Russell	Mercedes	183	2
3	L. Hamilton	Ferrari	183	1
4	L. Norris	McLaren	159	2
5	C. Leclerc	Ferrari	155	1
6	M. Verstappen	Red Bull	112	0
7	O. Piastri	McLaren	104	0
8	I. Hadjar	Red Bull	68	0
9	L. Lawson	RB	49	0
10	P. Gasly	Alpine	44	0
11	A. Lindblad	RB	23	0
12	F. Colapinto	Alpine	19	0
13	O. Bearman	Haas	18	0
14	G. Bortoleto	Audi	10	0
15	N. Hulkenberg	Audi	6	0
16	C. Sainz	Williams	6	0
17	A. Albon	Williams	5	0
18	E. Ocon	Haas	3	0
19	F. Alonso	Aston Martin	3	0
20	V. Bottas	Cadillac	0	0
21	S. Perez	Cadillac	0	0
22	L. Stroll	Aston Martin	0	0



A.K. Antonelli



G. Russell

F1 Constructors' standings

Pos	Team	Points	Wins
1	Mercedes	425	8
2	Ferrari	338	2
3	McLaren	263	2
4	Red Bull	186	0
5	RB	66	0
6	Alpine	63	0
7	Haas	21	0
8	Audi	16	0
9	Williams	11	0
10	Aston Martin	3	0
11	Cadillac	0	0



Badminton Men's ranking

#	Player	Points	Events
1	Jonatan Christie	87,631	17
2	Christo Popov	87,002	20
3	Kunlavut Vitidsarn	86,915	16
4	Chou Tien Chen	86,580	27
5	Anders Antonsen	85,405	17
6	Shi Yu Qi	84,075	12
7	Alex Lanier	78,715	16
8	Kodai Naraoka	76,530	20
9	Victor Lai	76,465	18
10	Li Shi Feng	71,683	16
11	Alwi Farhan	71,619	19
12	Lin Chun-Yi	71,274	19
13	Lakshya Sen	65,573	21
14	Loh Kean Yew	64,100	20
15	Toma Junior Popov	62,697	20



Lakshya Sen
Rank 13



Ayush Shetty
Rank 20

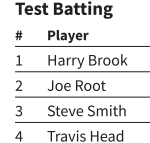


Test Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Harry Brook	874	898
2	Joe Root	850	932
3	Steve Smith	840	947
4	Travis Head	811	884
5	Temba Bavuma	775	806
6	Rachin Ravindra	740	740
7	Rishabh Pant	711	801
8	Shubman Gill	711	807
9	Daryl Mitchell	710	804
10	Babar Azam	709	882

Test Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Mitchell Starc	872	872
2	Jasprit Bumrah	862	908
3	Matt Henry	861	870
4	Pat Cummins	841	914
5	Marco Jansen	825	825
6	Kagiso Rabada	807	902
7	Scott Boland	804	820
8	Noman Ali	792	853
9	Josh Hazlewood	783	864
10	Nathan Lyon	731	812

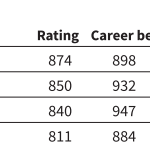


ODI Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Shubman Gill	801	841
2	Daryl Mitchell	794	840
3	Virat Kohli	767	908
4	Rohit Sharma	758	879
5	Ibrahim Zadran	719	756
6	Babar Azam	689	894
7	Joe Root	674	810
8	Shai Hope	673	782
9	Charith Asalanka	659	705
10	Harry Tector	653	730

ODI Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	714	775
2	Abrar Ahmed	675	675
3	Jofra Archer	649	682
4	Keshav Maharaj	645	737
5	Mitchell Santner	644	656
6	Maheesh Theekshana	641	680
7	Bernard Scholtz	613	631
8	Shaheen Afridi	604	691
9	Mehidy Hasan	602	722
10	Adil Rashid	599	671

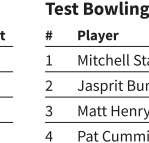


T20I Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Ishan Kishan	910	910
2	Sahibzada Farhan	848	848
3	Abhishek Sharma	819	931
4	Phil Salt	799	881
5	Pathum Nissanka	751	796
6	Tilak Varma	750	845
7	Jos Buttler	748	794
8	Harry Brook	734	734
9	Mitchell Marsh	706	706
10	Dewald Brevis	702	738

T20I Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	753	828
2	Abrar Ahmed	736	757
3	Adil Rashid	710	747
4	Adam Zampa	700	746
5	Nathan Ellis	675	678
6	Corbin Bosch	669	745
7	Wanindu Hasaranga	668	809
8	Mujeeb Ur Rahman	663	757
8	Varun Chakravarthy	663	818
10	Mohammad Nawaz	658	672



Top Indians



Sumit Nagal
Rank 234 ▲ 5 spots



Manas Dhamne
Rank 372 ▼ 4 spots



Sahaja Yamalapalli
Rank 342 ▲ 2 spots



Vaishnavi Adkar
Rank 389 ▲ 1 spot



Badminton Women's ranking

#	Player	Points	Events
1	An Se Young	1,21,287	15
2	Wang Zhi Yi	1,03,989	16
3	Akane Yamaguchi	1,02,576	18
4	Chen Yu Fei	86,651	15
5	Han Yue	77,038	14
6	Ratchanok Intanon	74,606	20
7	Putri Kusuma Wardani	72,023	18
8	Pornpawee Chochuwong	69,027	16
9	Tomoka Miyazaki	68,106	22
10	Pusarla V. Sindhu	65,401	14
11	Nozomi Okuhara	63,610	18
12	Kim Ga Eun	60,931	16
13	Line Christophersen	57,940	22
14	Michelle Li	57,427	21
15	Mia Blichfeldt	55,803	13



P.V. Sindhu
Rank 10



Unnati Hooda
Rank 25



Top Indians



Sumit Nagal
Rank 234 ▲ 5 spots



Manas Dhamne
Rank 372 ▼ 4 spots



Sahaja Yamalapalli
Rank 342 ▲ 2 spots



Vaishnavi Adkar
Rank 389 ▲ 1 spot



A ND-NDE

PASSING THE TEST

Hope to build on the confidence gained from SL series: Padikkal



PTI

I wanted to show everyone that I am capable of getting big runs like I have done throughout my First Class career and now I am really happy I showed it in the Test arena as well. Hopefully, I can take the confidence forward — India batter Devdutt Padikkal, after scoring 328 runs in the two-match series against Sri Lanka.

GIANT IN THE MAKING

Pujara praises Dinusha, says he can become one of Lanka’s greats



AP

Cheteshwar Pujara hailed Sonal Dinusha for his sensational performance against India, saying it took him back to the era of Sri Lankan giants Kumar Sangakkara and Mahela Jayawardene. “He can be one of the greats for his country. The way he batted on the last day of the second Test, it was a commendable effort”.

MEMORABLE MOMENT

Velavan defeats local hope to bag Budapest Squash Open crown



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

India’s Velavan Senthilkumar, seeded eighth, won the Budapest Squash Open after thrashing ninth-seeded Balazs Farkas of Hungary 11-4, 11-2, 11-3 in the final on Friday. The 28-year-old had defeated compatriot Veer Chotrani 9-11, 11-8, 11-7, 1-11, 12-10 in a last-four clash of the \$43,500 PSA Copper event.

REWARD

Hockey India announces ₹50 lakh for women’s team



HOCKEY INDIA

Hockey India on Friday announced a cash award of ₹50 lakh for the women’s team in recognition of its fifth-place finish at the World Cup. Salima Tete’s side defeated Germany 3-1 in Amstelveen on Thursday, marking India’s best result at the tournament since the fourth-place effort at the inaugural edition in 1974.

Praggnanandhaa storms to Grand Chess Tour title

The Chennai GM bounces back in style to pip defending champion Caruana in the final by displaying his supremacy in faster time controls, becomes the first Indian to win the prestigious event

CHESS

P.K. Ajith Kumar

He was trailing. And he was up against the World No. 2. And yet, there was almost a sense of inevitability to it. R. Praggnanandhaa duly defeated Fabiano Caruana and won the Grand Chess Tour. After losing the first game, he bounced back in great style to win the multi-format final at St. Louis on Thursday. He became the first Indian to win the most prestigious tour on the chess circuit. Caruana, in fact, was the champion of the Grand Chess Tour last year, and also in 2023. He had begun on the right note in the US city, winning the opening classical game of the final

against his 21-year-old rival from Chennai, whose blunder with his rook on the 28th move proved fatal. Praggnanandhaa, however, came back strongly in the second classical game, in which he was in control before an error of judgment allowed his American opponent to draw after 95 moves. Caruana thus maintained his lead, 9-3 (a classical win carried six points). The Indian, however, showed his supremacy in the faster time controls. He won both the rapid games – worth four points each – and thus took an 11-9 lead going into the blitz section. Caruana was in a must-win situation in the last blitz game, but Praggnanandhaa drew it with perpetual checks, giving him a 15-13 match victory. He is indeed looking unstoppable on the chess-



Unstoppable: Praggnanandhaa rallied to edge out Caruana and registered one of his biggest triumphs. FLICKR/GRANDCHESSTOUR

board. This is his second major success at St. Louis this month. Just a fortnight ago, he had won the Saint Louis Rapid & Blitz in spectacular style. He won the tournament by a margin of

1.5 points, over his nearest rival Javokhir Sindarov, this year’s World championship challenger. And Praggnanandhaa was leading on all five days of the event. Before Saint Louis, he

had recorded a career-best performance at Norway Chess in Oslo, where he emerged as the champion after beating the World No. 1 Magnus Carlsen twice in his hometown. The five-



time World champion has often spoken highly of him and once even named him as the player closest to him in style. That is indeed high praise. Pravin Thipsay, In-

dia’s third Grandmaster, believes Praggnanandhaa has earned it. “He has a great sense of what is required to win, and it is not about a better position or a complex posi-

tion,” Thipsay tells *The Hindu* over the phone from Mumbai. “He has a knack of where that initiative is and goes for non-simplification like Carlsen. And he goes beyond the book and is a very active player even when the positions are equal. He has become a very strong player practically.” Praggnanandhaa’s recent successes have come after he went through one of the worst periods of his career. He was so badly out of form in the year’s most crucial event – the Candidates tournament in Cyprus, where he was placed seventh in a field of eight. If he continues to play like this, he could be one of the favourites for the next Candidates. “Yes, he will be a great force,” says Thipsay.

Robinson and Archer run riot

PAKISTAN IN ENGLAND

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Ollie Robinson took four for 11 in 13 overs as Pakistan collapsed to 110 all out in the second Test against England at Lord’s on Friday. But on a day when 13 wickets fell in total, England slumped to 13 for two in its second innings on a pitch offering significant seam movement. The home side, however, recovered to 81 for three, earning a lead of 261 when bad light forced an early close to the second day. England is seeking an unassailable 2-0 lead in the three-match series. Pakistan’s slump either side of lunch left it 180 runs behind England’s first-innings score of 290. Fast bowler Jofra Archer, who did the initial damage, took three for 26. Only opener Azan Awaais offered resistance for Pakistan with 46 while Saud Shakeel (16) was the only other batter to get to double-figures. The scores: England 290 in 66.4 overs (Cox 55, Smith 61, Mohd. Abbas 4/73, Mohd. Ali 3/86) & 81/3 in 22 overs vs. Pakistan 110 in 37.2 overs (Awaais 46, Robinson 4/11, Archer 3/26).



Robinson. GETTY IMAGES

India’s path to WTC final becomes tougher despite the series win



Tall order: India is placed fifth in the WTC points table and has seven Tests left against New Zealand and Australia in this cycle. PTI

INDIA IN SRI LANKA

K.C. Vijaya Kumar
COLOMBO

Thursday’s slow winding down of the second Test, had shades of the 1980s. Back then as the game stretched into the mandatory overs of the fifth day, Sunil Gavaskar or a Javed Miandad would wheel their arm over. The fact that Shubman Gill, Yashasvi Jaiswal and Dhruv Jurel ambled towards the bowling crease, also reflected the way India’s fortunes had crashed in a drawn contest that was all about Sri Lanka’s fightback. During the course of this game at the Sinhalese Sports Club (SSC) Ground, a charity match in another venue had featured Arjuna Ranatunga and Aravinda de Silva. Just as nostalgia’s waves drenched the Sri Lankan cricketing fraternity, a hint of batting evolution was also underlined by the magnificent Sonal Dinusha. The southpaw amassed 420 runs averaging 140,

Sri Lanka-India Test series in numbers

BATTING	Inns	Runs	HS	Avg	100s/50s
Dinusha	4	420	133*	140.00	3/1
Padikkal	3	328	167	109.33	2/0
Jurel	3	173	115*	86.50	1/1
BOWLING	Inns	Wkts	BBi	SR	SWI
Suthar	4	16	6/55	40.62	1
Asitha	3	10	4/31	33.30	0
Prabath	3	9	4/109	61.33	0

and specifically his unbeaten 133 in the second innings, prevented India from sweeping the series 2-0. Just like how in the past, V.V.S. Laxman undermined Australia’s best-laid plans, Dinusha did the same with the Indians. The stalemate here and Bangladesh’s heroics at Darwin and the eventual 1-1 verdict in the series Down Under, has further affected India, placed fifth in the ICC World Test Championship (WTC) points table. The two-Test away series in New Zealand and the five games against Australia in the Indian backyard, have become must-win options for Gill’s men. If recency-bias forces a

revealed good Test bat-manship. His tons at Galle and in the Sri Lankan capital had both solidity and fluidity. The southpaw never got into a shell, kept the scoreboard ticking and perhaps has done enough to stay on at No. 3 even after Sai Sudharsan returns. Suthar, meanwhile, has an old-world feel. He goads the ball to spin a yarn and leads batters to their doom. While much has been discussed about a batting order that has moved on from Rohit Sharma, Cheteshwar Pujara, Virat Kohli and Ajinkya Rahane, it is a fact that the spin-quotient will miss the guile of R. Ashwin for sometime. While Rishabh Pant and Jurel made vital contributions with the bat, the no-balls peddled by the spinners, specifically Ravindra Jadeja, and the altercation between Jaiswal and Asitha Fernando, were all a cause for worry. The road ahead is critical and coach Gautam Gambhir and Gill have to forge a squad that will prosper both at home and away.

India goes down fighting to Belgium

HOCKEY WORLD CUP

Aashin Prasad
WAVRE (BELGIUM)

India could only manage an eighth-place finish in the hockey World Cup after a 3-4 penalty shootout loss to Belgium. India had fought back twice from a goal down to hold the co-host 3-3 in regulation time at the Belifus Arena here on Friday. At 2-2, veteran midfielder Manpreet Singh was struck near his eye as he put his body on the line to get on the end of Hugo Labouchere’s close-range shot. A bloodied Manpreet was helped off the pitch. But even as the Indian team could recover from the horror injury, Belgium pounced on an error to score through Nicolas de Kerpel. The goal was upheld despite India’s referral for a touch on the body in the build-up, which added to a frustratingly mixed afternoon for skipper Harmanpreet Singh. In the first quarter, he was the recipient of a five-minute suspension for an embarrassing situation when his side fielded 12 players before being hand-

ed a green card in the third. But in between them, he struck with his trademark powerful drag-pushes to twice equalise, the second one coming with just seconds left on the clock to level the scores. However, he couldn’t find a way past Vincent Van-nasch in the shootout as did his teammate Sukhjeet Singh. India goalkeeper Mohith H.S. committed too early as Belgium managed to find the net four times to end its home World Cup with something to cheer about. India silenced the home side five minutes into the start when Abhishek Nain’s shot deflected in off Alexander Hendrickx for the opening goal. But Belgium continued to suffocate India with its full court press and launched a barrage of shots. While Suraj Karkera resisted in the opening quarter, Mohith couldn’t stop an unmarked Roman Duvekot from equalising before Labouchere scored from Belgium’s fifth PC. The result: India 3 (Abhishek 5, Harmanpreet 30, 59-pc) drew with Belgium 3 (Duvekot 21, Labouchere 22-pc, de Kerpel 46). Belgium won 4-3 in penalty shootout.



Bittersweet: It was a mixed day for Harmanpreet. HOCKEY INDIA



Federer. AFP

Federer to be inducted into Tennis Hall of Fame

Associated Press
NEW YORK

Roger Federer loved to win, of course, and at the peak of his career, almost always did. All those victories and trophies he piled up would have made Federer an icon in tennis, but they were only part of the reason he enjoyed playing. Only after he finished competing did he realise how much that impacted his legacy in the sport. “There was a lot of talk about my personality and what I brought to the game overall when I wasn’t on court, which surprised me,” Federer said. “I thought it was about forehands, backhands, saving break points, victories and all that stuff. “But it is about what you were remembered for... how did you behave in the locker rooms or in the corridors or maybe with the media, tournament directors, ball kids,” added the 45-year-old from Switzerland. Federer will have a chance to reflect back on it on Saturday when he is enshrined in the International Tennis Hall of Fame in Newport, Rhode Island.

INBRIEF



Neeraj Chopra qualifies for Diamond League Finals

Javelin thrower Neeraj Chopra has qualified for the Diamond League Finals to be held in Brussels on September 5 despite competing in just two events. Neeraj secured 12 points after finishing second in both the Doha and Lausanne DL events on June 19 and August 21, respectively, to take the sixth spot in the standings and make it to the winner takes it all grand finale. The standings were updated at the end of the 14th and last leg of the series in Zurich on Thursday. Of the 14 DL meetings of the year, five featured men’s javelin throw.

LIVE TELECAST

- England vs Pakistan: Second Test, Day 3, Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 3.30 p.m.
- Hockey World Cup (Women): Star Sports First & JioHotstar, 4.30 & 7.30 p.m.
- T20I tri-series: South Africa vs Zimbabwe, FanCode, 5.30 p.m.
- Women’s T20 Asia Cup: Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 8 p.m.
- Serie A: Unite8 Sports 1, 2 & Z5 App, 12.15 a.m. (Sunday)
- LaLiga: FanCode, 1 a.m. (Sunday)

Jonty’s all-round show powers Kings to final

The skipper follows up his blistering hundred with a three-wicket haul as Purani Dilli goes down tamely; the Central Delhi team will take on Superstarz on Sunday in a rematch of Qualifier 1

DPL

Sports Bureau
NEW DELHI

Jonty Sidhu’s unbeaten 106 off 46 balls paved the way for Central Delhi Kings to hammer Purani Dilli-6 by 72 runs at the Arun Jaitley Stadium on Friday and enter the final of the Delhi Premier League.

Kings will face South Delhi Superstarz in Sunday’s final, a rematch of Qualifier 1 where the latter prevailed.

In addition to his blitzkrieg with the willow, Jonty also sparked with the ball, scalping three for 25 in three overs.

Having been asked to bat in Qualifier 2 by Purani Dilli skipper Anuj Rawat, Kings racked up a daunting total of 218 for five in 20 overs. Jonty came up with a



Captain’s knock: Jonty smashed five fours and 10 maximums in his 46-ball unbeaten 106. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

knock befitting his status as captain, smashing five fours and 10 sixes at No. 4.

In response, Samarth Seth scored a 28-ball 45 at

the top of the order, but Purani Dilli faded away as the chase progressed and was eventually bowled out for 146. Besides Jonty’s

three breakthroughs, Money Grewal, Tejas Baroka and Gavnish Khurana also took two wickets each.

Superstarz rout Riders

Skipper Shweta Sehrawat led the way with an unbeaten 75 as South Delhi Superstarz eased past East Delhi Riders by 60 runs in the women’s section. Batting first, Superstarz posted 179 for six. Riders managed 119 for eight in reply.

The scores: Qualifier 2: Central Delhi Kings 218/5 in 20 overs (Jonty Sidhu 106 n.o., Pankaj Jaswal 2/41) bt Purani Dilli-6 146 in 17.4 overs (Samarth Seth 45, Dhananjai Singh 34, Money Grewal 2/27, Jonty Sidhu 3/25, Tejas Baroka 2/19, Gavnish Khurana 2/32).

South Delhi Superstarz women 179/6 in 20 overs (Tanisha Singh 40, Shweta Sehrawat 75 n.o., Parunika Sisodia 2/23) bt East Delhi Riders women 119/8 in 20 overs (Disha Nagar 3/25, Himakshi Choudhary 2/20).

Dos Santos, Russell make history



Obstacles, what? Dos Santos and Russell set the track ablaze with scintillating performances on Thursday. REUTERS

DIAMOND LEAGUE

Agencies
ZURICH

Two World records were broken less than 40 minutes apart at the Diamond League here on Thursday, with 400m hurdler Alison dos Santos of Brazil making his way into the history books and Masai Russell of the USA breaking the women’s 100m hurdles mark.

Dos Santos crossed the line in 45.80 seconds to take 0.14 seconds off the record set by Karsten Warholm of Norway at the To-

kyo Olympics in 2021.

Nigeria’s (47.50s) Ezekiel Nathaniel was third.

Russell, the 2024 Olympic gold winner, set a time of 12.09 seconds, which is 0.03s faster than the previous record held by Nigeria’s Tobi Amusan. Amusan was second in a season-best effort of 12.23s while European champion Nadine Visser came third in 12.34s.

Sri Lankan javelin thrower Rumesh Pathirage extended his excellent run, producing a massive 92.07 throw to capture the top spot. The winning throw was his sixth attempt.

Scheduling mess: a clash of fixtures could leave Rest of India with depleted squad for Irani Cup

CRICKET

Amol Karhadkar
MUMBAI

A scheduling mess by the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) could leave Rest of India with a depleted squad for its prestigious Irani Cup contest against Ranji Trophy champion Jammu and Kashmir.

Following the convention, the Irani Cup is scheduled in Srinagar, the home of Jammu and Kashmir, from October 1 to 5.

The fixture, however, clashes with the second of two multi-day games between India-A and Austra-



Next assignment: Jammu and Kashmir will face Rest of India in the Irani Cup. FILE PHOTO: K. MURALI KUMAR

lia-A, set to be hosted in Puducherry from September 29 to October 2.

The Rest of India squad has traditionally been the most star-studded First Class unit after the Test

side. The overlap of the matches, though, will leave the National selection committee to take a difficult decision: field a full-strength team against Australia-A or prioritise the Irani Cup as

the premier domestic fixture.

The selectors could also attempt a balancing act by splitting the prominent players between the sides. An insider at the BCCI Centre of Excellence, which is closely involved in planning the A-tour itinerary along with the Board’s cricket operations wing, said that the situation could have been avoided had the three one-dayers against Australia-A been scheduled between the two four-day games.

But, the clash could provide an “opportunity” for more players to make a case at a higher level.

Sandeep Patil, the 1983 World Cup champion and

a mentor of Mumbai’s Ranji team, preferred to look at that aspect.

“Instead of 11 or 12, double the number of players will get an opportunity to deliver a strong show,” Patil said.

“Due to a very tight calendar, such clashes have become a part of it. I won’t even term it unfortunate since it’s not just happening in India. All the major cricket nations are facing the same dilemma,” he said.

The schedule: Irani Cup: Oct. 1 to 5 (Srinagar). India-A vs. Australia-A: Multi-day: Sept. 22 to 25 and Sept. 29 to Oct. 2; One-dayers: Oct. 6, 9 & 11. Both multi-day and one-dayers at Puducherry.

SNAPSHOTS

Raphinha, Lopez strike again as Barcelona beats Athletic Bilbao

BARCELONA: Raphinha and Fermin Lopez goals helped Spanish champion Barcelona beat Athletic Bilbao 2-0 on Thursday in LaLiga to continue its perfect start to the season.

The results: Celta Vigo 1 (Aspas 14) lost to Osasuna 2 (Barja 54, Budimir 64-pen); Barcelona 2 (Raphinha 37, Lopez 82) bt Athletic Bilbao 0.

Final round of IAME Series karting today

The fifth and final round of the IAME Series India will be conducted under lights at the Madras International Karting Arena (MIKA), Sriperumbudur near here on August 29. The IAME Series India is



Opening salvo: Raphinha puts Barcelona ahead. AP

promoted by RA Motorsports and organised by the Madras Motor Sports Club (MMSC). The winners will represent India at the IAME Asia Finals in Macau scheduled from December 11 to 13.

The Championship leaders in their respective classes are: Mini u-10: Aaruthan Prabhu (Kartkrew Motorsports).

Mini: Shiv Neel (NKRA by KKM); Junior X30: Rehan Khan Rasheed (Momentum Motorsports); Senior X30: Kairav Roberson (MSPORT).

WFI issues strict anti-doping advisory

WRESTLING

Sports Bureau
KOLKATA

After losing two Asian Games berths due to positive dope tests, a ‘deeply concerned’ Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) on Friday issued a strict advisory for the wrestlers and support staff in the run-up to next month’s mega event in Japan.

Recently, freestyle wrestler Mukul Dahiya (86kg) and Greco-Roman wrestler Deepanshu (130kg) failed dope tests and were provisionally suspended.

“We requested for their replacements, but as per rules replacements are possible in case of injuries only. The United World Wrestling (UWW) is strict about doping. We are likely to lose out on fielding wrestlers in two weights,” WFI president Sanjay Singh told *The Hindu*.

The WFI had been flagging the issue of wrestlers staying out of the National camp without due permission, which Sanjay felt was one of the reasons for positive results.

“These wrestlers go back to their domestic coaches even though we

Freestyle wrestler Dahiya (86kg) and Greco-Roman wrestler Deepanshu (130kg) failed dope tests recently and were provisionally suspended. The WFI had also been flagging the issue of wrestlers staying out of the National camp without due permission

spend a lot on coaching at the National camp. These coaches persuade the wrestlers to consume prohibited substances assuring them that it would not reflect in the tests. Ultimately, as a country we lose out and face embarrassment.”

In its latest advisory, the WFI asked the wrestlers to exercise ‘highest degree of caution and personal responsibility.’

It reminded athletes that ignorance, complete reliance on coaches and inadvertent consumption of banned substances could not absolve anyone of responsibility. It also underlined that athletes in registered testing pools must provide accurate whereabouts information.

Sanjay regretted that the WFI’s awareness programmes have not produced big results so far. “Still, we will conduct more awareness programmes,” he said.

Arsenal faces wounded Villa; focus on Savio as Tottenham meets Newcastle

PREMIER LEAGUE

Agence France-Presse
MANCHESTER

Arsenal is out to inflict more damage on a wounded Aston Villa, while Tottenham is desperate to see some return for its \$408 million investment in new signings when Newcastle visits north London.

Liverpool boss Andoni Iraola also makes his home bow at Anfield against Nottingham Forest and Manchester United badly need to bounce back from an opening weekend shocker at Hull when Ipswich visit Old Trafford.

Ezri Konsa could make his Arsenal debut to a frosty reception on his return to Villa Park.

The England international is just one of a series of departures from Villa in recent months which has torn apart the side that won the Europa League and finished fourth in the Premier League last season.

A depleted Villa found themselves 4-0 down to Brighton inside 31 minutes last weekend.

Worse could be to come against an Arsenal side brimming with the confidence of champions.

Mikel Arteta’s men have swatted aside Manchester



Waiting game: The depth of options available to the Gunners means Konsa may even have to wait for his chance to shine despite the absence of Saliba. GETTY IMAGES

City and Coventry 3-0 to pick up the Community Shield and make a perfect start to their title defence.

Villa captain John McGinn remains hopeful they can still have a successful season as long as Unai Emery remains in charge.

Spurs have fans have been waiting years for their club to be the Premier League’s big spenders, but were brought back down to earth with a

3-0 pummelling by Brentford last weekend.

Since then Savio and Omar Marmoush have joined from Manchester City for combined fees that could reach nearly £150 million.

Savio’s £75 million price tag has attracted astonishment from some after failing to make the grade in two years at City, but Roberto De Zerbi is confident the Brazilian can help transform Spurs’ fortunes.

Arteta braced for ‘tough’ Martinelli and Jesus exits



Inevitable: Arsenal is facing a tricky period with the likely departure of Martinelli and Jesus. GETTY IMAGES

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Mikel Arteta revealed he has had difficult conversations with forwards Gabriel Martinelli and Gabriel Jesus as both Brazilian internationals appear set to depart Arsenal. “It’s inevitable, at some point you need to have certain discussions and say certain things that sometimes are tough,” said Arteta.

Martinelli left training early on Thursday amid speculation he is set for a move to Saudi side Al Hilal for a fee that could reportedly rise to £50million (\$68 million).

“I think everybody knows and recognises how much we love Gabi (Martinelli). Whatever the outcome is, it will be because everybody agrees to that,”

added Arteta.

Jesus has fallen well down the pecking order during an injury disrupted time in north London and was not even included in training on Thursday as he enters the final 12 months of his contract.

“It’s something to do with the numbers that we have in the squad at the moment and the way we’re managing that kind of situation individually with all the players – they have some personal situations,” Arteta said of the former Manchester City striker.

Arsenal has been linked with bolstering its forward line with a move for Atletico Madrid’s Julian Alvarez. The Argentine is caught in an acrimonious stand-off after Atletico refused to let him depart the Spanish capital for Barcelona.